

Mother Courage and Her Children



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF BERTOLT BRECHT

The son of a Protestant mother and Catholic father, Brecht was born and raised in Augsburg, a small city near Munich, Germany. Distraught to see his classmates drafted into World War I, he signed up for medical school to avoid the draft. But he fell in love with his theater classes instead and decided to dedicate himself to the artform. He befriended many of Germany's major directors and performers, then started writing plays, which won him the prestigious Kleist Prize for young writers in 1922. He moved to Berlin in 1925 to work as a dramaturge for the renowned director Max Reinhardt. For the next eight years, he collaborated with a wide variety of political artists, actors, and activists while developing the hallmarks of his style of "epic theater," including his preference for analysis over entertainment, his frequent use of historical settings as analogies to the present, and his consistent Marxist critiques of capitalism. He first achieved widespread recognition for [The Threepenny Opera](#) in 1928, and he married Helene Weigel, an actress and frequent collaborator, in 1930. Brecht left Germany within weeks of Hitler's rise to power in 1933, spending six years in Denmark before continuing on to Sweden, Finland, and eventually the United States, where he briefly worked in Hollywood before being blacklisted for his left-wing views. His best-known works, including *Mother Courage and Her Children*, are largely his political plays from this period of exile. But after the U.S. government called him to testify before the House Un-American Activities Committees in 1947, he moved back to Europe, where he briefly settled in Zürich and then finally returned to (East) Berlin and set up the Berliner Ensemble, the theater company he would direct for the rest of his life. Although his art advocated for left-wing causes throughout his life, he never joined the Communist Party and was deeply ambivalent about East Germany's repressive, authoritarian political tactics. He died of a chronic heart condition in 1956, but as of 2023, his Berliner Ensemble is still alive and well.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Mother Courage and Her Children is set over twelve years in the middle of the Thirty Years War of 1618-1648, a devastating conflict that drew in all of Europe's major powers and killed as much as half of Central Europe's population. The Holy Roman Empire, where the war started, was actually a knotty assortment of smaller states, cities, and landholdings whose individual rulers were allowed to set the official religion (either Catholicism or Lutheranism). The war began in Bohemia, the

present-day Czech Republic, when the devout, intolerant Catholic Ferdinand II was appointed as king. Protestant nobles revolted and established an opposition government, and other leaders from around Europe began pouring money and soldiers into the conflict, forming complex alliances based on a combination of religion, family relationships, and—above all—political and financial opportunism. After the Catholic alliance secured control of Bohemia and surrounding regions by 1625, Christian IV of Denmark joined the conflict to protect Protestants—and when his intervention failed, King Gustavus Adolphus of Sweden followed him in 1630. The Swedish intervention turned the war in the Protestants' favor, but at great cost. Not only did King Gustavus die in battle in 1632, but the 1630s were one of the most miserable periods in history for Europeans, with starvation, plague, and massacres ravaging modern-day Germany in particular. The second half of Brecht's play focuses on this period, as *Mother Courage* accompanies the Swedish army around Bavaria. But actually, the first part of the play is set during the last five years of the Polish-Swedish wars of 1600-1629. When the play begins, *Mother Courage* has been running the Swedish army's canteen for at least a decade; her children have known nothing but war, and when they move from Poland to Germany in 1630, very little changes. (And when it ends, in 1636, there are still a dozen years left in the war.) Indeed, this is Brecht's way of emphasizing that war is similar, regardless of the time, place, and formal reason for the conflict. After all, he wrote this play directly after the Nazi invasion of Poland launched World War II.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Bertolt Brecht is remembered as perhaps the most influential playwright of the mid-20th century, and many of his plays are still frequently produced around the world. His major early work was [The Threepenny Opera](#) (1928), an adaptation of John Gay's 1728 ballad opera [The Beggar's Opera](#) and a critique of capitalism set in the London criminal underground. But Brecht undoubtedly wrote his most influential plays during the middle period of his life, particularly the years he spent in exile from the Nazi regime in Scandinavia and the U.S. Besides *Mother Courage and Her Children*, these works include the biographical *Life of Galileo* (1938), the antifascist satire *The Resistible Rise of Arturo Ui* (1941), and the ambiguous moral fables *The Good Person of Szechwan* (1941) and [The Caucasian Chalk Circle](#) (1944). Brecht dedicated the last decade of his life mostly to directing plays and mentoring younger dramatists; his most influential work from this period is actually the essay "A Short Organum for the Theatre" (1949), which describes Brecht's unique approach to the theater and is often considered his

manifesto, along with “The Modern Theatre Is the Epic Theatre” (1930) and “On Experimental Theatre” (1940). In short, Brecht believed in “epic theater” that inspires audiences to rational analysis and political transformation, rather than just entertaining them.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Mutter Courage und ihre Kinder (Mother Courage and Her Children)
- **When Written:** September 1939
- **Where Written:** Stockholm, Sweden
- **When Published:** 1941 (first performance in Zürich)
- **Literary Period:** Modernism
- **Genre:** Historical Play, Epic Theater, Political Theater, War Play
- **Setting:** 1624–1636 in Sweden (Dalarna), Poland-Lithuania (Walmozja), and the Holy Roman Empire (Leipzig, Ingolstadt, Fichtel Mountains, Halle)
- **Climax:** Kattrin is shot and killed while beating on a drum to warn the residents of Halle about the invading Catholic army.
- **Antagonist:** Soldiers (both the Protestant and Catholic armies), the war, hunger, cold

EXTRA CREDIT

Authorship Controversy. Brecht wrote most of his plays through intense collaboration with associates in the theater world, including prominent actors, songwriters, and even his lovers. *Mother Courage and Her Children* was no exception. The composers Paul Burkhard and Paul Dessau wrote the music, and the actress, translator, and writer Margarete Steffin—who was also Brecht’s secretary and lover—made major contributions to the script. Although it’s impossible to say exactly how much of it was her work, many 21st-century scholars argue that she should be listed alongside Brecht as a coauthor.

From Stage to Film. In 1961, to honor Brecht’s life and legacy, East Germany commissioned the directors of Brecht’s Berliner Ensemble to film their performance of *Mother Courage and Her Children*. Brecht’s widow Helene Weigel starred as Mother Courage in this movie version of the play.



PLOT SUMMARY

Mother Courage and Her Children explores the horror and futility of war by following Mother Courage on a 12-year odyssey around Europe during the famously brutal Thirty Years’ War of 1618–1648. Stoic, savvy, and enterprising, Mother Courage hopes to make a fortune by following the Swedish army in her

wagon, selling food, liquor, and supplies. But her quest fails, and her three children (Eilif, Kattrin, and Swiss Cheese) all get caught up in the war and die violent, early deaths. Like much of Bertolt Brecht’s work, this play is experimental and provocative, intended less to entertain audiences than to shape their political consciousness. It is full of songs but not a musical, packed with metaphors but not an allegory, and set in the distant past but intended specifically as a warning to Germany and the world on the eve of World War II.

The play opens with “The Song of Mother Courage,” in which Mother Courage sings that soldiers should come buy her food and liquor before they go to die in battle. The first scene is set in rural Sweden in 1624. Two soldiers (Top Sergeant and Recruiting Officer) stop Mother Courage and her children and demand to see their business license. The whole family introduces itself, explaining that Mother Courage got her nickname after pulling her wagon straight through the middle of a raging battle and that the children’s fathers are various men she encountered during her travels around Europe. The soldiers convince Eilif to join the war by promising him wealth and glory, and then Mother Courage foretells the Sergeant’s death—and all three of her children’s—by drawing lots.

Mother Courage and Eilif reunite by accident two years later in Poland. Mother Courage sells the Swedish Commander’s personal Cook a capon at a greatly inflated price, and then the Commander returns to his tent with Eilif, who boasts about outsmarting and slaughtering a group of peasants. Together, Eilif and Mother Courage sing “The Fishwife and the Soldier,” which is about an idealistic young man who dreams of becoming a war hero, runs out into the sea, and drowns.

The third scene takes place three years later. An Ordinance Officer sells Mother Courage his last bullets for liquor money and a young sex worker named Yvette Pottier recounts how her one great love, the Cook from the last scene, betrayed and abandoned her. Shortly thereafter, the Cook arrives with the Chaplain and asks for Swiss Cheese—who is now the Swedish army’s paymaster. But Swiss Cheese and Yvette have both already left. The Chaplain praises Sweden’s King Gustavus for fighting a holy war to liberate Poland from Catholicism, but the Cook and Mother Courage argue that he’s really after money and power. Suddenly, the Catholics attack. The Cook leaves, and then Kattrin struts past wearing Yvette’s flashy hat and red boots, which Mother Courage takes and hides. Swiss Cheese returns and makes a plan to hide his cashbox, and Mother Courage takes down her Protestant flag. They all hide for three days.

Two Catholic soldiers (Sergeant and One Eye) confront Kattrin—they want Swiss Cheese’s cashbox. But Kattrin never speaks: she can only communicate through grunts and gestures. Swiss Cheese doesn’t understand her warning and quickly gets captured, but he manages to throw his cashbox in the river first. Mother Courage gets a loan from one of Yvette’s

dates, an elderly Colonel, and tries to purchase Swiss Cheese's freedom with it. But she tries to negotiate down the price, and by the time she finally makes a deal, it's too late: the Catholic army has already executed Swiss Cheese. Soldiers bring his body to Mother Courage and demand to know if she was helping him hide out; she claims not to know him, and the soldiers send his body to the dump for burial.

In the next scene, Mother Courage goes to the German Captain's tent to protest the fine she was charged for protecting Swiss Cheese. A furious Young Soldier approaches the tent and promises to kill the Captain, who stole his reward for swimming in the river (and presumably recovering Swiss Cheese's cashbox). Mother Courage sings the Young Soldier "The Song of the Great Capitulation," in which she explains how she gave up on expecting justice and learned to make compromises instead. She and the Young Soldier both leave instead of making their complaints.

Two years later, somewhere in Bavaria, the Chaplain begs Mother Courage to give him her unsold shirts so that he can tear them up, use them as bandages, and save a peasant family dying of gunshot wounds. She refuses, so he steals them. Katrin runs into the family's farmhouse and saves their baby, and Mother Courage gives liquor to the Catholic soldiers who massacred the town—and steals their fur coat for payment.

The sixth scene takes place in the Catholic army's canteen tent during a prominent general's funeral. But instead of attending the event, most of the soldiers are hanging out drinking. Mother Courage debates whether or not to stock up on more supplies, and after the Chaplain sings about how the war will continue, she does. She looks forward to the day when she will be rich, the war will end, and Katrin will marry—but then, a soldier attacks Katrin, leaving a hideous scar over her eye and ruining her chances at marriage.

In the following scene, Mother Courage learns that King Gustavus is dead, and the war is over. She responds by panicking: she just bought new supplies and thinks that peace will bankrupt her. The Cook visits and gets into a nasty personal dispute with the Chaplain, and then Yvette Pottier returns, realizes that the Cook is her long-lost lover, and starts a second vicious argument. Mother Courage and Yvette leave, and then two soldiers pass by with Eilif. They explain that he attacked an innocent peasant family—which is a crime now that the war is over—and lead him off to be executed. When Mother Courage returns and excitedly announces that the war has restarted, it's too late. The Cook admits to seeing Eilif but doesn't reveal his fate.

The following winter is particularly harsh. The remaining characters (Mother Courage, the Cook, and Katrin) are out of merchandise, stranded in a Bavarian mountain village, and reduced to begging. The Cook receives a letter explaining that his mother has died and that he will inherit her inn, and he excitedly invites Mother Courage—but not Katrin—to follow

him. Mother Courage and the Cook stand outside the local Parson's house and sing him "The Song of the Wise and Good," which describes how wisdom, selflessness, and faith lead people to ruin. The Parson invites them inside and gives them soup. Having heard everything, Katrin starts packing her things—but before she can go, Mother Courage returns, brings her soup, and explains that she wasn't going to abandon her. Instead, Mother Courage and Katrin leave the Cook behind and trudge on with their wagon. They pass a large farmhouse and hear one of its residents singing about how cozy and comfortable it is to spend the winter inside by the fire.

Two years later, Mother Courage and Katrin have parked their wagon in front of a peasant family's house near the town of Halle. One night, while Mother Courage is doing business in town, a group of soldiers bangs on the peasant family's door and forces the son (Young Peasant) to guide them to town. The boy's father (Old Peasant) climbs on the roof and sees a huge army marching into Halle, then gets down and starts desperately praying with his wife (Old Peasant Woman) and Katrin. When the peasants mention that their grandchildren live in town, Katrin quietly pulls a drum out of the wagon and climbs on the farmhouse roof. Then, she starts beating the drum furiously to warn the townspeople about the coming army. The soldiers run back and tell her to stop, but she refuses. She continues beating the drum zealously for several minutes, defying the soldiers' orders. She keeps playing even as the soldiers threaten to shoot her, find a musket, set it up, and fire, killing her.

The play's final scene shows Mother Courage sitting with Katrin's corpse and wondering if she is just sleeping. Mother Courage sings a lullaby about her children's fate, naively remarks that at least Eilif is alive, and asks the peasant couple to bury Katrin. She marches on with her wagon and asks the Catholic army—the same men who killed Katrin—if she can accompany and trade with them. The play closes with the soldiers singing the same number that appeared at the beginning: "The Song of Mother Courage."



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Mother Courage – The protagonist and title character is a middle-aged woman who works alongside the Swedish army, selling the soldiers food, **alcohol**, and supplies out of her **wagon**. Her real name is Anna Fierling, but everyone in the army has known her as "Mother Courage" ever since she famously drove her wagon through the middle of a fierce battle in Riga (modern-day Latvia) in 1621. She is dedicated and enterprising but also greedy and unempathetic. Her three children (Eilif, Katrin, and Swiss Cheese) all follow her on her travels and die violent deaths during the play, in part because of

her actions. Notably, they all have different fathers, whom she met on her various tours around Europe with the army. (It's entirely possible that some or all of her children were the product of rape.) Still, her family is a cross-section of all Europe, which may be Brecht's way of suggesting that the continent's people are all kin and that World War II—like the Thirty Years' War—would needlessly tear them apart. Over the course of the play, Mother Courage demonstrates that she will do almost anything to increase her profits, even when this means abandoning people who have proven loyal to her or putting her children in danger. She even despairs when the war ends and rejoices when it restarts because she thinks her commercial prospects improve when the fighting gets worse. Worse still, she refuses to help a family of dying peasants because they cannot afford to pay, and at the end of the play, she even joins up with the Catholic soldiers who just killed her beloved daughter, Kattrin, because she sees this as her best commercial opportunity. In a nutshell, Mother Courage represents the spirit of capitalism, which Brecht saw as one and the same as the spirit of war and imperial expansion.

Eilif – Eilif is Mother Courage's oldest son and Swiss Cheese and Kattrin's half-brother. Bold, proud, and impulsive, his personality is fitting for a soldier, and the Recruiting Officer and Top Sergeant exploit this fact to manipulate him into joining the Swedish army. Eilif's passion for "skinning peasants" wins him accolades during the war—the Swedish Commander even calls him a hero in the second scene. But his greed and audacity also lead to his demise, as he continues robbing and murdering innocent peasants even after the war (temporarily) ends. (The stage directions ironically call this "one heroic deed too many.") In the song "The Fishwife and the Soldier," he points out that his father was also a soldier, yet he recognizes that his gusto will prove to be his fatal flaw. Notably, his last wish before he goes to his execution is to have some **brandy**. While he is nonchalant about taking others' lives, it seems, he is a coward when it comes to losing his own. Just like his mother does with courage, his brother with honesty, and his sister with love, he represents how war corrupts the virtue of fortitude, turning it into an engine of violence and destruction.

Swiss Cheese – Swiss Cheese ("Schweizerkas") is Mother Courage's younger son, Eilif and Kattrin's half-brother, and the first of Mother Courage's children to die in the play. Honest and loyal, he becomes the paymaster for a regiment in the Swedish army. But his virtues also lead to his demise: after the Catholic army defeats the Swedes in the third scene, Mother Courage suggests that the family pocket the money in Swiss Cheese's cashbox, but Swiss Cheese tries to hide it instead (so that he can eventually return it to his commanders). He gets caught and executed; Mother Courage tries to buy his freedom but fails because she wastes too much time trying to bargain down the price.

Kattrin – Kattrin is Mother Courage's only daughter and Eilif

and Swiss Cheese's half-sister. She is mute: she only communicates through gestures, actions, and grunts, so the audience must guess at her intentions by interpreting a combination of her behavior and Mother Courage's comments about her. Nevertheless, Kattrin keenly observes everything that happens around her and arguably turns out to be the most insightful and ethical character in the whole play by the end. Specifically, she gives the play its haunting, bombastic climax when she beats on a drum to warn the people of Halle that the Catholic army is coming to massacre them—and sacrifices her life in the process. This echoes an earlier scene in which she rushed into a besieged peasant family's farmhouse to save a baby, and it shows that her overriding concern is her desire to save innocent people (especially children) from the trauma of the war. This makes sense in light of Mother Courage's comment that Kattrin's muteness began when a soldier traumatized her (probably by sexually assaulting her) when she was a child. At the same time, Kattrin clearly dreams of escaping the war, living a free and ordinary life, and, above all, falling in love. (She expresses this dream in part by strutting around in Yvette Pottier's **red boots**.) In fact, Mother Courage declares that Kattrin's greatest aspiration is to get married after the war ends. Yet this also becomes all but impossible after soldiers attack her in the sixth scene, leaving her with a disfiguring facial scar. Kattrin thus represents war's horrifying toll on the innocent. Of course, her final, fateful warning about the horrors to come is really intended for a different audience altogether: the people of Europe in 1939.

The Chaplain – The Chaplain is a Protestant minister who works for the Swedish army, then joins Mother Courage and her family on their odyssey around Europe after his unit gets captured in the third scene. His job is to provide a religious justification for the war by telling the soldiers that their mission is really to save the Catholics from damnation. However, the war shakes his faith, until it becomes clear that he no longer believes in what he preaches. Perhaps he never did—in fact, nobody else seems to. After all, his **heavy drinking** and sexual advances on Kattrin and Mother Courage suggest that he probably joined the church for personal gain rather than out of religious conviction. He's even willing to replace the Protestant flag with the Catholic one after getting captured, which makes it clear that he's more afraid of dying in the war than going to Hell. Nevertheless, he's still a caring humanitarian—for instance, he goes to great lengths to save a dying peasant family in the fifth scene. He has a love-hate relationship with the Cook, and at different times, he both agrees with and condemns Mother Courage's desire for the war to continue (so she can profit). In the eighth scene, he follows Eilif to his execution, presumably to perform his last rites, and then disappears for the rest of the play. For Brecht, the Chaplain's corruption is a metaphor for all religion, which is more about social control than morality.

The Cook – The Cook is an opportunistic, womanizing, pipe-smoking Dutchman who works for the Swedish Commander as a private chef in the second and third scenes. Like Mother Courage, his primary interest is profiting off the war. He also has a salacious backstory with Yvette Pottier, whom he once seduced and then cheated on, and who knows him as “Peter Piper.” (She confronts him when they reunite in the eighth scene.) He has difficult relationships with both the Chaplain, who **drinks** with him but also knows that he is an immoral leech, and Mother Courage, who price-gouges him over a capon in the second scene but is delighted to see him in the eighth scene (even though he has only visited her in search of alcohol). He follows Mother Courage through Bavaria in the ninth scene, then decides to return to Utrecht to run his late mother’s inn and invites her (but not Kattrin). Mother Courage and Kattrin leave him behind, and his fate is left uncertain at the end of the play.

Yvette Pottier – Yvette Pottier is a sex worker who accompanies the Swedish army on its campaigns around Europe, hoping to make a living in the short term and eventually strike it rich in the long term by marrying one of the soldiers. Her saga began when the Dutch Cook seduced her in her hometown, and she agreed to start following him around Europe; he ended up cheating on and abandoning her, which led her to sex work. When the audience first meets her in the third scene, the soldiers have been avoiding and spreading rumors about her, but she manages to seduce the Colonel and help Mother Courage pawn her **wagon** in an effort to save Swiss Cheese. When Yvette returns years later in the eighth scene, she is older, heavysset, and presumably wealthy—she married the Colonel’s brother, who since died. She reunites with the Cook. Her story shows how war makes a mockery out of love, turning it into little more than a transaction. In this way, she serves as a foil for both Mother Courage—who also sees a great business opportunity in the war—and Kattrin, who dreams that a man will save her from her dreadful life through marriage, but who could also easily end up exploited or drawn into sex work if she idealistically tried to pursue that dream during the war. The **red boots** that Yvette wears on her dates are also an important symbol of Kattrin’s femininity and desire for freedom throughout the play.

Top Sergeant – The Top Sergeant is one of the soldiers who recruit Eilif into the war in the first scene. (The other is the Recruiting Officer.) The Sergeant boasts about his success in the military and makes fun of Eilif’s reservations about fighting, but when Mother Courage foretells that he will die, he grows terrified, which shows that he was lying about his bravery all along.

The Sergeant and One Eye – The Sergeant and One Eye (who wears an eye patch) are the Catholic soldiers who capture Swiss Cheese during the third scene. Mother Courage tries and fails to buy Swiss Cheese’s freedom from One Eye with Yvette

Pottier’s help, and then the Sergeant brings her Swiss Cheese’s body at the end of the scene to determine if she knows him.

The Young Soldier – In the fourth scene, the Young Soldier furiously approaches the Captain’s tent to demand his monetary reward. (The play strongly implies that he retrieved Swiss Cheese’s cashbox from the river.) Feeling that he has been treated unjustly, the Young Soldier even threatens to kill the Captain—until Mother Courage convinces him to lower his expectations with “The Song of the Great Capitulation.”

The Captain – The Captain is the Catholic officer to whom Mother Courage and the Young Soldier try to complain in the fourth scene. The Young Soldier alleges that the Captain stole his reward money and spent it partying. But both Mother Courage and the Young Soldier give up before they can meet the Captain, who never appears onstage.

The Parson – The Parson is a local religious leader in a small town in Bavaria’s Fichtel Mountains. Unlike the rest of his town, he finds soup even in the war’s meanest days, which speaks to the church’s corruption. However, he shares his soup with Mother Courage and the Cook after they sing him a song about how religious virtue is useless (“The Song of the Wise and Good”). It’s unclear whether the Parson invites them inside because he agrees with their pessimistic views, because he doesn’t understand their song, or just because he pities them.

The Lieutenant – In the penultimate scene, the Lieutenant leads the group of soldiers who terrorize the peasant family (Old Peasant, Old Peasant Woman, and Young Peasant) on their way to attack the town of Halle. He murders the Young Peasant and Kattrin, who warns the townspeople of the pending attack with her drum. His penchant for senseless violence reflects the cruelty of the war as a whole.

MINOR CHARACTERS

The Recruiting Officer – The Recruiting Officer manipulates Eilif into joining the war effort in Sweden in the first scene. He remarks that his job is incredibly difficult, as most young Swedish men know that the war is essentially a death sentence.

The Swedish Commander – The Swedish Commander is the leader of Eilif’s regiment, and he effusively praises Eilif for slaughtering a crowd of peasants in the second scene.

The Ordnance Officer – The Ordnance Officer is a soldier with the Swedish army who is in charge of supplies like weapons and ammunition. In the third scene, he sells Mother Courage his last bullets in exchange for liquor, which underlines how desperate and weary soldiers become during the Thirty Years’ War.

The Colonel – The Colonel is the elderly but high-ranking soldier whom Yvette Pottier convinces to buy Mother Courage’s **wagon** in the third scene. (Actually, he gives her a loan for 200 guilders and takes the wagon as collateral.) Yvette

ends up marrying his brother.

The Regimental Clerk – The Regimental Clerk is an apathetic, cynical bureaucrat in the Catholic army.

Old Peasant – The father of the peasant family in Halle, the old peasant collaborates with the Lieutenant out of fear and grieves with Mother Courage after they both lose their children (Young Peasant and Katrin).

Old Peasant Woman – The mother of the peasant family in Halle, the old peasant woman prays for God to save the townspeople and later promises Mother Courage to give Katrin a dignified burial.

Young Peasant – The Old Peasant and Old Peasant Woman's son, the young peasant does the Lieutenant's bidding at gunpoint until Katrin inspires him to stand up for the townspeople by beating her drum. He yells out in support of her, and in response, the Lieutenant immediately murders him.

King Gustavus Adolphus – The King of Sweden and a talented military commander, Gustavus leads the Swedish intervention in the Thirty Years' War, turning the conflict in the Protestants' favor. However, he dies at the Battle of Lützen in 1632, during scene eight of the play.

TERMS

Guilder – Guilders were gold coins frequently used throughout Europe (particularly in the Holy Roman Empire) from the 13th through 18th centuries.

Heller – Hellens were small, low-value silver coins commonly used throughout central Europe from the 1300s to the 1800s.

Thaler – Thalers were several kinds of large, high-value silver coins used between the 1500s and the 1800s in central Europe. At the time of the Thirty Years' War, a *Reichsthaler* was technically worth 576 heller, although in practice, the exchange rate fluctuated significantly due to differences in currency systems, coin debasement, and changes in the supply of precious metals. Notably, "dollar" is just the Anglicized version of the German word "thaler."

Paymaster – An army paymaster is the officer in charge of paying soldiers and other employees their salaries.

Capon – A capon is a castrated male chicken.



WAR, FAILURE, AND DESPAIR

Mother Courage and Her Children is above all an emphatic condemnation of war. The play takes place during the Thirty Years' War, a brutal conflict between Catholics and Protestants that devastated Europe in the 1600s, killing as much as half the population of what is now Germany through violence, starvation, and disease. In the play, Mother Courage and her children Eilif, Swiss Cheese, and Katrin make a living operating a canteen for the Swedish army out of their **wagon**. They follow the army around Europe for over a decade, turning a meager profit by selling food, alcohol, and supplies while they watch the soldiers around them face the harsh realities of combat and scarcity, abandon their faith and dreams, and then die pointless, miserable deaths. After all, there is no true winner in the Thirty Years' War: even the victors starve, suffer horrible atrocities, and lose track of why they're fighting in the first place. The protagonists are no exception: at first they dream that the war will bring them glory (Eilif), an honest job (Swiss Cheese), marriage (Katrin), and riches (Mother Courage), but they are all wrong. The children instead die horrific deaths in the war, leaving Mother Courage penniless, desperate, and completely alone at the end of the play. In fact, the play suggests that even the powerful people who start and lead wars—like the Swedish Commander and King Gustav—often do so in pursuit of childish fantasies of power and prosperity, only to lead their peoples into nothing but division and despair.

Brecht's message is clear: war is self-destructive folly. It destroys its participants' humanity by rewarding them for brutality and destruction while stamping out their capacity for honesty and compassion. Plenty of propaganda—including much classical literature—teaches people to associate war with honor, prosperity, and strength. But Brecht suggests that this is a naïve fantasy at best and a cynical manipulation at worst. Because of such propaganda, millions of idealistic young people sign up for wars that turn them into corpses and immoral monsters. Written during the fateful year of 1939 and in the first month following the Nazi invasion of Poland (which formally set off World War II), this play is first and foremost a warning cry to Europe about the perils and folly of war.



PROFIT, VIOLENCE, AND POWER

Mother Courage's most distinctive (and most jarring) attribute is that she views the war primarily as a business opportunity. She cares far more about profit than about supporting the troops, making a name for herself, or even who lives and dies. Indeed, she makes her priorities clear when she tells Swiss Cheese, "Nothing *must* come, not even the seasons. Only your books *must* balance." Mother Courage despairs when the war ends before she can sell off all her inventory, but she then rejoices when the war resumes; she refuses to give the Chaplain unsold shirts to use



THEMES

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as bandages to save a dying peasant family, leaving him with no choice but to steal them. In this sense, like successful arms dealers, military contractors, and commodity speculators today, she acts like an ideal capitalist, making business decisions purely based on her balance sheet while ignoring everything that lacks monetary value, including justice and human life. Even when her profit-seeking bankrupts her and leads to her children's deaths, she stoically pulls her **wagon** on; she never doubts her dedication to commerce.

But Mother Courage is not a deranged, greedy fanatic. Rather, she is merely a pragmatist who understands the truth about war far better than the other characters—and takes it to heart. She sees that war is a moneymaking scheme for rich and powerful men like King Gustavus, who seek to profit by mutilating, exploiting, and robbing the masses. And she sees doing exactly the same thing as her only chance to rise up in the world—she knows that, if she isn't willing to play dirty and accept brutality, she will lose out to competitors who *are* willing to do this. Thus, through the character of Mother Courage, Brecht shows his audiences that profit and violence are two sides of the same coin. In fact, he suggests that war and capitalism share the same fundamental spirit: they are just elaborate forms of robbery.



LOVE AND NURTURE

In theory, Mother Courage's war profiteering is an expression of motherly love: she wants to make enough money to give her children a secure, comfortable life. But in practice, her work requires moral compromises that make it all but impossible for her to show true motherly love. She might feel responsible for her children, but she also exposes them to the trauma and violence of war—which leads to their deaths—and loses the compassion, empathy, and sense of justice that real nurture requires. For instance, she constantly berates Katrin, and she indirectly gets Swiss Cheese killed by trying to bargain down the bounty on his life in the moments before his execution.

Crucially, Katrin *does* preserve the maternal instinct that Mother Courage loses. But this is hard to notice at first because Katrin doesn't speak: she has not spoken a word since a soldier attacked her when she was a young girl. Still, she demonstrates her nurturing qualities in the fifth scene, when Mother Courage wants to leave a peasant family's baby for dead and Katrin runs into the family's home to save it instead. Thus, even though Katrin communicates primarily through grunts and gestures, it becomes clear that she deeply yearns to give other children the maternal love that she never received. This dynamic is the key to understanding the play's climax, in which Katrin sacrifices her own life to warn the people of a local town that soldiers are coming to massacre them—but only once she learns that there are children there. Notably, after Katrin's death, Mother Courage fails to confront the depth of

her loss—she instead sings a lullaby to Katrin's corpse and remarks that maybe she is just sleeping. This reflects how, in her ill-fated attempt to save her children through the war effort, Mother Courage has actually sacrificed the personal qualities that make deep human connection possible. In contrast, Katrin demonstrates that people can hold onto their capacity for love and nurture even in the darkest of situations—so long as they do not stoop to the level of committing atrocities themselves.



FAITH AND IDENTITY

The Thirty Years' War was technically a conflict between Catholics and Protestants, but *Mother Courage and Her Children* makes it clear that the war was really about power, not God. While the competing empires used religion to forge alliances and justify violence, Brecht suggests that their faith was never sincere. For instance, the Chaplain initially preaches that death in battle is really holy martyrdom on behalf of the Protestant cause, but by the play's halfway point, he has started pretending to be Catholic so that the German army will spare him, and he has even started begging Mother Courage to sleep with him. Perhaps even the most dedicated believers can lose their faith amidst the perils of war, or perhaps the Chaplain was never particularly devout and actually joined the church out of self-interest. In contrast, ordinary people seem to actually believe that God cares about the war: in the penultimate scene, the Old Peasant and Old Peasant Woman desperately pray for God to save their village, only for Katrin to *actually* save the town by banging on her drum and waking everybody up. Brecht's implication is clear: only humans can save humans from atrocities; religion is far more likely to cause violence than prevent it. This is because it's a straightforward way to divide people who would not otherwise see themselves as different. For example, because the war's combatants are all Europeans who share the same languages and cultural heritage, it is often difficult for the audience (and even the characters) to tell which side any given army belongs to. But as a left-wing artist and avowed atheist who had recently fled Nazi Germany, Brecht knew all too well how oppressive regimes can use religion to draw a sharp distinction between friends and foes. Through his depiction of the futile conflict between Catholics and Protestants in the Thirty Years' War, he aimed to remind his fellow Germans that they were being manipulated into turning against ethnic and religious minorities. Thus, Brecht presents religion as not just a useless lie, but actually as a form of social control that turns people against one another.



THEATER, PERFORMANCE, AND HISTORY

More than any individual work, Bertolt Brecht is best remembered today for his revolutionary

approach to theater, which he saw less as a form of entertainment than a political tool, a means to shape public opinion and eventually change the world. A conventional drama or comedy is supposed to give audiences a sense of connection with the characters throughout and a feeling of resolution at the end. But Brecht sought to do the opposite. By filling his plays with inconsistent and unexpected elements, like stage directions that give away what will happen in a scene and cheery-sounding songs about the brutality of war, Brecht hoped to leave his audiences uneasy and force them to think. (He called this the “*estrangement effect*” and his overall approach *dialectical* or *epic theater*.) Specifically, Brecht wanted audiences to connect the dots between his plays and the political, economic, and historical factors that shape their lives. This is why he addressed the urgent perils of Nazism and World War II by writing *Mother Courage and Her Children*, which focuses on a seemingly unrelated war in the 1600s. Namely, he wanted Germans to make the connection between a familiar, dark episode from their past and the clear and present danger the Nazi regime posed to Europe in 1939. Like Katrin, who sacrifices her life to warn villagers of a coming massacre even though she cannot speak in a conventional way, Brecht uses unconventional tools—estrangement and historical analogy—to warn Germans of the devastation that they will both cause and suffer from during World War II.

leads her to a lifetime of violence and instability. But she accepts that her lot in life is to keep pulling it, and she never considers leaving it behind. After all, she has always lived from it and she has no alternative—in a way, it is her very identity. Notably, Brecht is *not* praising her perseverance and namesake courage. In fact, he famously wished for audiences to see the fault in her ways rather than empathizing with her. Perhaps, like Germans on the eve of World War II, Mother Courage should have left her wagon behind and chosen a different life, rather than simply resigning herself to facing certain death and facilitating the destruction of Europe.



ALCOHOL

Alcohol represents the futility and indignity of war. Throughout the play, soldiers go and risk their lives for a meager salary, then waste that whole salary on Mother Courage's brandy in an effort to forget the horrors they have witnessed. When they actually experience war, they realize that war is not worth it—but it is already too late to leave, so they drink instead. This is clear from the play's first lines, in which Mother Courage sings to an imaginary army captain, offering his men the opportunity to “drink before they die.” She points out that, if the captain gets his men drunk, they might be willing to do what is asked of them in war—which presumably includes taking on dangerous tasks or even losing their lives. In this way, Mother Courage describes alcohol as a trick to grease the wheels of war: not only does it get smart men to do stupid things in a pointless war that does not benefit them, but it also helps them forget what they have done and seen. By the end of their service, most of the soldiers are either dead or broke, and alcohol has helped with both. So it's little surprise that, from the play's events, alcohol seems to be Mother Courage's best-selling product. And yet she lives out the same futile cycle, profiting in the short term but losing out both financially and personally in the long term, and she also ends the play penniless and desperate.



RED BOOTS

Yvette Pottier's provocative red boots represent Katrin's desire for love and freedom. In the third scene, Katrin tries them on and Mother Courage responds by comparing her to a sex worker (like Yvette), taking them away, and making plans to sell them. In a later scene, after soldiers attack Katrin, Mother Courage tries to gift Katrin the boots as a token of goodwill, but Katrin refuses them.

Since Katrin doesn't speak, moments like these offer rare and valuable insight into her true desires, complicated feelings about men, and her relationship with her mother. When she first takes Yvette's boots, she acts out a fantasy of feminine beauty—which will presumably help her find the man whose love can save her from the brutality of war. Such desires are



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE WAGON

Mother Courage's wagon is the overriding symbol at the center of the play; Brecht's audiences, readers, and performers will rightly interpret it in countless different ways, but one of its clearest functions is as a metaphor for the burden of fate. In short, Mother Courage's attachment to her wagon represents the inescapable fact that our lives are determined by forces beyond our control, and we have to make the best of the circumstances in which we find ourselves.

The wagon serves as Mother Courage's home and business, but it's also her vehicle for traveling around Europe and her shield during battles along the way. The first line in the play is a stage direction describing the wagon, which remains onstage throughout nearly the whole performance, and Mother Courage's last action in the final scene is to hitch herself to it, alone and resolute, and trudge onward into an uncertain future. The wagon burdens her physically because she has to pull it, economically because all her wealth gets locked up in it, and spiritually because it leads her children to their deaths and

perfectly natural for a young woman coming of age, and yet Mother Courage recognizes that the only way for Katrin to seek love during war would be as a sex worker. In fact, Mother Courage explains that Katrin's greatest desire in life is to get married, but this is impossible until the war ends. This is why she takes the boots away. But she also can't resist the temptation to sell them and turn a profit—even if it would mean turning the symbol of Katrin's dream into just another commodity. When Mother Courage later repents and tries to return the boots, it is already too late: the attack has left Katrin with a scar that means no man will ever marry her. Perhaps Katrin refuses to take the boots because she now knows that men will not offer her salvation from her life with Mother Courage, or perhaps she does so because she does not want Mother Courage to dictate when and how she can feel free and independent.

Related Symbols:



Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

The play opens with the actors singing this overture, "The Song of Mother Courage," while traveling on the wagon. This song recurs throughout the play (most memorably in the closing scene) as a motif representing Mother Courage's role in the war. And it's a bombastic, theatrical way for Brecht to introduce his play. But it shouldn't be mistaken for a part of the play itself, because it's not really the characters singing—specifically, the lines the actors are singing are not continuous with what the characters they portray do and believe. This is true of all the play's songs: far from being lighthearted entertainment, they are actually a form of serious commentary on the characters and their decisions. This is part and parcel of Brecht's "distancing effect"—he encourages his audience to actively analyze his work and look for meaning instead of simply observing and enjoying it.

"The Song of Mother Courage" describes how Mother Courage's canteen contributes to the war effort: she keeps the soldiers fed (and drunk) so that they can fight. But the song presents this in the darkest possible terms, emphasizing how she sustains an enterprise that systematically maims and slaughters young men—and suggesting that, if she didn't keep the men full and let them drink themselves in a stupor, perhaps they wouldn't volunteer to be maimed and slaughtered. The middle verse in this passage, which is the song's chorus, reflects the brutal ethos at the heart of the war: men march through the harsh winter to certain death for no discernible purpose except to help the King get slightly more land and money.

Scene 1 Quotes

☞ What they could use around here is a good war. What else can you expect with peace running wild all over the place? You know what the trouble with peace is? No organization. And when do you get organization? In a war. Peace is one big waste of equipment. Anything goes, no one gives a damn. See the way they eat? Cheese on rye, bacon on the cheese? Disgusting! How many horses they got in this town? How many young men? Nobody knows! They haven't bothered to count 'em! That's peace for you!!

Related Characters: Top Sergeant (speaker), The Recruiting Officer



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Grove Press edition of *Mother Courage and Her Children* published in 1991.

Prologue Quotes

☞ HERE'S MOTHER COURAGE AND HER WAGON!
HEY, CAPTAIN, LET THEM COME AND BUY!
BEER BY THE KEG! WINE BY THE FLAGON!
LET YOUR MEN DRINK BEFORE THEY DIE!
SABERS AND SWORDS ARE HARD TO SWALLOW:
FIRST YOU MUST GIVE THEM BEER TO DRINK.
THEN THEY CAN FACE WHAT IS TO FOLLOW—
BUT LET 'EM SWIM BEFORE THEY SINK!

CHRISTIANS, AWAKE! THE WINTER'S GONE!
THE SNOWS DEPART, THE DEAD SLEEP ON.
AND THOUGH YOU MAY NOT LONG SURVIVE,
GET OUT OF BED AND LOOK ALIVE!

YOUR MEN WILL MARCH TILL THEY ARE DEAD, SIR,
BUT CANNOT FIGHT UNLESS THEY EAT.
THE BLOOD THEY SPILL FOR YOU IS RED, SIR,
WHAT FIRES THAT BLOOD IS MY RED MEAT.
FOR MEAT AND SOUP AND JAM AND JELLY
IN THIS OLD CART OF MINE ARE FOUND:
SO FILL THE HOLE UP IN YOUR BELLY
BEFORE YOU FILL ONE UNDERGROUND.

Related Characters: Mother Courage, Eilif, Swiss Cheese (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 23-24

Explanation and Analysis

The play opens with the Top Sergeant and Recruiting Officer lamenting the sorry state of the Swedish war effort. In particular, they complain that they're struggling to recruit because Swedish men simply don't want to sacrifice their lives to go fight far away in Germany. After all, King Gustavus has ostensibly joined the war to protect German Protestants—not his own people—and many, including Mother Courage, suspect that he's really in it for personal gain.

But as they observe the village of Dalarna, the soldiers frame the local people's opposition in different terms. They view the locals as lazy and disorganized because they haven't had "a good war" to force them to use all their resources. In other words, the soldiers think, the town has abundance when it really needs efficiency, and nothing would be better for efficiency than military discipline. Of course, audiences will probably realize that what the soldiers are really thinking is that they'd like to capture some of the town's abundance for themselves and their higher-ups—they are using the language of efficiency and unity as excuses for plunder. Brecht opens with this conversation because he sees this obsession with efficiency, surplus, and order as the kind of thinking at the heart of war, fascism, and capitalism.

☛☛ (She draws a knife.) Yes, just you try, and I'll cut you down like dogs! We sell cloth, we sell ham, we are peaceful people!

Related Characters: Mother Courage (speaker), Eilif, Top Sergeant, The Recruiting Officer

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 29

Explanation and Analysis

When the soldiers try to recruit Eilif into the Swedish army, this is Mother Courage's response. She refuses to let her sons fight in the war; they will merely sell goods to the people who fight in the war. Needless to say, Mother Courage has seen the danger and suffering involved in the fighting firsthand, and she knows better than to expose her

sons to it. While she opposes the war in this narrow sense, Mother Courage seems to think that *she* is different—more noble and peaceful, and therefore safe from the war's worst effects—because she does not get directly involved in the fighting. In other words, she thinks that, even if the war is immoral, *profiting* from the war is perfectly fine. But this attitude is just as self-serving as her ironic insistence that her family is "peaceful"—all while she pulls a knife on someone. When considered in the context of the play as a whole, this passage makes Brecht's broader message clear: Mother Courage's job is *not* morally neutral or "peaceful"—rather, she is just as much a cog in the war machine as the soldiers, and thus partially responsible for the destruction from which she profits.

☛☛ Well, there's yours, Eilif, my boy! (As EILIF *takes the slip, she snatches it and holds it up.*) See? A cross!

[...]

Take yours, Swiss Cheese. You should be a better bet—you're my *good* boy. (SWISS CHEESE *draws.*) Don't tell me it's a cross? Is there no saving you either? Just look, Sergeant—a black cross!

[...]

(to KATTRIN) Now all I have left is you. You're a cross in yourself but you have a kind heart. (She *holds the helmet up but takes the slip herself.*) Oh dear, there must be some mistake! Don't be too kind, Katrin, don't be too kind—there's a black cross in your path! So now you all know: be careful! Be very careful! (MOTHER COURAGE *climbs on her wagon preparing to leave.*)

Related Characters: Mother Courage (speaker), Eilif, Swiss Cheese, Katrin, Top Sergeant

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 31-32

Explanation and Analysis

Partway into the first scene, Swiss Cheese makes the surprising (and entirely unexplained) announcement that Mother Courage can see the future. Mother Courage then draws lots, selecting pieces of paper that represent the fate of the Top Sergeant and her three children. All four have black crosses on them, which means that all four people will

die soon in the war.

Audiences unfamiliar with Brecht's work may find this plot twist deeply confusing. Why would Brecht introduce a random fortune-telling element, and why would his protagonist give away the story's ending? But actually, by making the audience ask these questions, Brecht is already fulfilling his artistic goals. Recall that he wanted his audiences to analyze his work's meaning and come out with a new understanding of their own lives.

Thus, in addition to foreshadowing the play's tragic ending—and hammering home Brecht's anti-war message—this scene also encourages the audience to think critically about the relationship between fate, choice, and death. At this point, Mother Courage could choose to stay home and save her children's lives, but she does not. Why? Perhaps she thinks that she has no choice but to follow the war, as she has been doing nearly all her life. Or perhaps she cynically thinks that the profit would be worth the loss. Regardless, what's clear is that Brecht also wants to remind his audiences of the perils in *their* future in 1939, as war breaks out in Europe and they are increasingly hurtling toward a completely foreseeable, tragic fate of their own.

☛ When a war gives you all you earn
One day it may claim something in return!

Related Characters: Top Sergeant (speaker), Mother Courage

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 33

Explanation and Analysis

The play's first scene ends with this aphorism from the Top Sergeant. His meaning is clear: people who get involved in the war might initially expect to benefit from it, but in reality, they tend to lose at least as much as they gain. Of course, this is ironic because Mother Courage has just predicted that *he* will die, too. But the main purpose of this line is to confirm that Mother Courage's attempts to profit from the war will, indeed, cost her all three of her children. In fact, she won't get her profits either: she will end the play poorer than she began it. So her fantasies never come to fruition, and she pays a heavy cost for projecting them onto the war.

It's easy to describe her fate in terms of divine or cosmic punishment, but Brecht probably would have shied away from that kind of language. His point is not that some

greater power is punishing warmongers for their actions—in fact, he certainly thinks there is no such higher power, and injustice in war often *doesn't* get punished. Rather, his point is that war is an uncontrollable storm of violence and injustice, and anyone who touches it is likely to get hurt. People largely base their expectations about war on stories they hear about it, but the reality is far more cruel, senseless, and unrewarding.

Scene 2 Quotes

☛ MOTHER COURAGE. My eldest. It's two years since I saw him. He must be *high* in favor—the Commander inviting him to dinner! And what do you have to eat? Nothing. The Commander's guest wants meat! Take my advice: buy the capon. The price is one hundred hellers.

(The COMMANDER has sat down with EILIF and the CHAPLAIN.)

COMMANDER. (*roaring*) Dinner, you pig! Or I'll have your head!

COOK. This is blackmail. Give me the damn thing!

Related Characters: Mother Courage, The Cook, The Swedish Commander (speaker), Eilif, The Chaplain

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 36

Explanation and Analysis

The second scene begins with Mother Courage selling a capon (a castrated rooster) to the Cook for the outlandishly inflated price of 50 hellers. The Cook resists, but when Eilif and the Commander return to the tent and the Commander angrily demands meat from the Cook, Mother Courage takes the opportunity to double her price and make a hefty profit. A win for her son has become a win for her—but Brecht forces the audience to ask, at what cost? Eilif is a war criminal who massacres peasants, and Mother Courage is a shameless war profiteer who takes advantage of scarcity and desperation to raise prices. Through their self-interest, they not only harm others but also morally degrade themselves. (Of course, the Commander is no better: he treats the Cook on whom he depends for survival like a subhuman animal.) Worst of all, Mother Courage's first instinct upon seeing her son is not to meet and embrace him, but rather to manipulate the situation into a higher profit margin. She shamelessly puts business above family, and as a result, she will soon lose both.

☛ EILIF. I laughed. And so we got to talking. I came right down to business and said: "Twenty guilders an ox is too much, I bid fifteen." Like I wanted to buy. That foxed 'em. So while they were scratching their heads. I reached for my good sword and cut 'em to ribbons. Necessity knows no law, huh?

COMMANDER. What do you say, keeper of souls?

CHAPLAIN. Strictly speaking, that saying is not in the Bible. Our Lord made five hundred loaves out of five so that no necessity should arise. So when he told men to love their neighbors, their bellies were full. Things have changed since his day.

COMMANDER. (*laughing*) Things have changed!

Related Characters: Eilif, The Chaplain, The Swedish Commander (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 37-38

Explanation and Analysis

Eilif tells the Commander how he managed to massacre a group of peasants and steal their oxen. He used a trick he clearly learned from his mother—haggling prices—and then took the opportunity to murder the peasants in cold blood. Not only are his actions reprehensible, but Brecht draws a clear link between them and Mother Courage's business, which is based on the same principle: greed, self-interest, and accumulation at any cost. Worse still, Brecht shows how war rewards such viciousness, ultimately handing power to the most immoral and sadistic people.

Eilif justifies his actions with the famous adage, "Necessity knows no law," which he falsely assumes to be a quote from the Bible. Of course, his argument is absurd: he wasn't motivated by necessity at all. He didn't *need* the peasants' oxen any more than the peasants did, and he certainly didn't *need* to murder anyone to get to them. But he will use any explanation he can to justify his actions. Of course, the real problem is not necessity but the war, which rewards lawlessness. This is a metaphor for religion's role in war more broadly: powerful people use misleading, self-serving interpretations of scripture to justify whatever they happen to want. And this makes the Chaplain's comments particularly amusing, as he all but admits that God has forsaken them. This is precisely the opposite of what he is supposed to say—that they are fighting a holy war for a noble cause.

Scene 3 Quotes

☛ I'm letting you have the bullets for two guilders. Dirt cheap. 'Cause I need the money. The Colonel's been drinking for three days and we're out of liquor.

Related Characters: The Ordnance Officer (speaker), Mother Courage

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 42

Explanation and Analysis

The third scene begins with a particularly dark and despicable scene: an Ordnance Officer, the soldier in charge of guarding arms and ammunition, tries to sell Mother Courage bullets in exchange for alcohol. Not only is he shirking his duties, but he's also putting his and his comrades' lives at risk. But he doesn't seem to care, whether because he assumes that he will die anyway or because he knows that the army is so corrupt that nobody will stop him. Mother Courage initially refuses his offer, not on the grounds of morality but rather because she would prefer not to get in trouble with the army—but then she gladly accepts when he agrees to lower the price. Clearly, she has no more qualms than he does, and she thinks she can resell the bullets for a higher price (even if it ends up being to the Swedes' enemies). This exchange neatly captures the depth of the corruption, cruelty, and despair in the war—and it makes it even clearer that Mother Courage is in no way morally innocent just because she isn't carrying arms.

☛ CHAPLAIN. My dear Cook, you talk as if dying for one's beliefs were a misfortune—it is the highest privilege! This is not just any war, remember, it is a religious war, and therefore pleasing unto God.

COOK. I see that. In one sense it's a war because of all the cheating, plunder, rape, and so forth, but it's different from all other wars because it's a religious war and therefore pleasing unto God. At that it does make you thirsty.

Related Characters: The Chaplain, The Cook (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 46

Explanation and Analysis

The Chaplain and Cook come to Mother Courage with news from Eilif, and the Cook takes the opportunity to ask her for a drink. The Chaplain responds with these brief lines about the war's true, holy purpose—although it's unclear whether he's being serious or sarcastic. Regardless, Brecht certainly wants the audience to see the irony here: there is nothing holy about this war, neither in its motivations nor its conduct. The Cook's sarcastic response shows that he doesn't believe this at all; if anything, his comments suggest, the religious justification gives soldiers leeway to act *even more* immorally. And over the course of the play, it will become clear that nobody believes in the war's religious justification, not even the Chaplain himself. In reality, the King hires men like the Chaplain not because he believes in holy war, but rather because religion is a powerful tool to control people: if he can convince his *soldiers* that this is a holy war, perhaps they will fight with some zeal.

☛ MOTHER COURAGE. I must get you two something to drink, or you'll be making improper advances out of sheer boredom.

CHAPLAIN. That is indeed a temptation—said the Court Chaplain as he gave way to it. And who is this captivating young person?

Related Characters: Mother Courage, The Chaplain (speaker), Katrin, The Cook

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 47

Explanation and Analysis

The Chaplain and Cook approach Mother Courage to ask for brandy—which is the main reason the play's male characters start conversations with her at all. Then, she makes this offhand comment about the men “making improper advances,” and the Chaplain offers this strange response, in which he first announces that he's going to make such advances and then does exactly that. (The “captivating young person” is Mother Courage's daughter, Katrin.) The Chaplain is supposed to be pious and celibate, but he has already made it clear that he only preaches religious values—he doesn't live up to him. His blatant lust is just another example of how he proves no better than the

other selfish, exploitative men who populate the play.

But the Chaplain's meta-narration is far more surprising than his hypocrisy. Regardless of whether he is narrating his internal monologue, reminding himself of his line, or briefly taking on the director's role, he clearly breaks character, mentions himself in the third person, and tells the audience exactly what he's going to do before he does it. This is another key example of Brecht's alienation technique: by shifting the audience's perspective, if even for just a moment, the Chaplain reminds the audience that they are watching a work of art and that the actors are real people portraying fictional ones. He interrupts the flow of the audience members' attention, forcing them to briefly analyze the play instead of just experiencing it uncritically.

☛ COOK. And King Gustavus liberated Poland from the Germans. Who could deny it? Then his appetite grew with eating, and he liberated *Germany* from the Germans. Made quite a profit on the deal, I'm told.

CHAPLAIN. That is a calumny! The Swedish king puts religion first!

MOTHER COURAGE. What's more, you eat his bread.

COOK. I don't eat his bread: I bake his bread.

MOTHER COURAGE. He'll never be conquered, that man, and you know why? We all back him up—the little fellows like you and me. Oh yes, to hear the big fellows talk, they're fighting for their beliefs and so on, but if you look into it, you find they're not that silly: they do want to make a profit on the deal. So you and I back them up!

Related Characters: Mother Courage, The Chaplain, The Cook (speaker), King Gustavus Adolphus

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 48

Explanation and Analysis

When the Cook points out the absurdity in King Gustavus Adolphus's war, both the Chaplain and Mother Courage are scandalized. The Cook asks why the King of Sweden would bother to invade Poland and Germany and suggests that his real reason was his “appetite” and thirst for profit. But the Chaplain insists that the King's real motive is religion—even though everyone else seems to agree that the King is just using religion as an excuse for getting what he wants. Mother Courage offers a different take: of course the King is in the war for profit, she argues, but this is precisely why

they should trust him. People who follow profit act rationally and predictably in search of it, and the people who support them can share in the spoils, too.

In this way, Mother Courage succinctly explains why so many people chose to join King Gustavus's war—and, Brecht suggests, the other wars that have plagued Europe throughout history, including World War II. Her comments also capture the basic worldview of modern capitalism: everything in the world is based on self-interest, and anyone who appears to act for the sake of anything else (like religion) is just making excuses—probably to manipulate people into doing what they want. Brecht's response to these ideas is nuanced but clear: while he shows that people certainly act ruthlessly for the sake of self-interest during the war, he also suggests that they end up undermining their own self-interest in the process. Mother Courage's model may describe war, but it doesn't describe humanity. And needless to say, the noblest characters in the play—most of all Kattrin—are heroes precisely because they are *not* selfish.

☞ YVETTE (*re-enters, pale*). You've done it—with your haggling. You can keep your wagon now. He got eleven bullets in him. I don't know why I still bother about you, you don't deserve it, but I just happened to hear they don't think the cash-box is really in the river. They think it's here. And they think you were in with him.

Related Characters: Yvette Pottier (speaker), Mother Courage, Swiss Cheese, Kattrin

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 64

Explanation and Analysis

Mother Courage's plot to save Swiss Cheese backfires: using Yvette as an intermediary, she tries to bargain down the price for his freedom and wastes time; the soldiers execute him before she can strike a deal. Perhaps worst of all, they *do* agree to a new price—but only once it's too late. He's already dead, and his death was both unnecessary and senseless. Mother Courage's haggling convinces the soldiers that she still has Swiss Cheese's cashbox, so they come for her next.

Brecht's message is clear: war is a game of meaningless

destruction, and when people become so obsessed with profit and self-interest that they lose track of the value of human life, they end up destroying that life. Mother Courage is at least partially responsible for Swiss Cheese's death, and her profit-seeking means that she was not able to give him the maternal love he deserved. While it's clear that she suffers for her actions, it's just as clear that she doesn't *truly* take responsibility or consider changing her ways.

☞ SERGEANT. There's a man here we don't know the name of, but he has to be registered to keep the records straight. He bought a meal from you. Look at him. See if you know him. (*He draws back the sheet.*) You know him? (MOTHER COURAGE *shakes her head.*) What? You never saw him before he bought that meal? (MOTHER COURAGE *shakes her head.*) Lift him up. Throw him on the garbage dump. He has no one that knows him. (*They carry him off.*)

Related Characters: The Sergeant and One Eye (speaker), Mother Courage, Swiss Cheese

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 64

Explanation and Analysis

The Catholic Sergeant who executed Swiss Cheese brings his body to Mother Courage, ostensibly as a record-keeping exercise, but really because he suspects that she has his cashbox. (His plan is to seize the box and punish her for hiding it—perhaps by executing her, too.) But Yvette has warned Mother Courage in advance, so she is aware that she cannot admit to knowing Swiss Cheese. This tragic scene ensues: Mother Courage confronts the body of the son she failed to save, but must avoid showing any kind of grief, lest she give away her relationship to him. But with her characteristically stoic attitude, she doesn't find this so difficult.

Unlike most other scenes in the play, in this scene Brecht actually *does* want emotional reactions from his audience: he wants them to share in Mother Courage's grief as a way to see the folly in her ways. He shows the human cost of war's cruel, senseless violence, which Mother Courage also participates in by making a living from the war. The irony in Swiss Cheese's death also shows how war twists virtue into its opposite: the Sergeant assumes Mother Courage has the cashbox because he assumes that Swiss Cheese was

dishonest, but in reality, the problem is that Swiss Cheese is *honest* and actually *did* get rid of the cashbox.

Scene 4 Quotes

☞ MOTHER COURAGE. You're hungry. You're angry. I understand.

YOUNG SOLDIER. Talking'll get you nowhere. I won't stand for injustice!

MOTHER COURAGE. How long? How long won't you stand for injustice? One hour? Or two? It's a misery to sit in the stocks: especially if you leave it till then to realize you do stand for injustice.

Related Characters: Mother Courage, The Young Soldier (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 66

Explanation and Analysis

In the fourth scene, Mother Courage approaches the Catholic Captain to make a complaint. The Catholic army has just destroyed her wagon and assessed her a hefty fine, in theory for her involvement with Swiss Cheese, but in reality just because they knew they could get away with it. Desperate and penniless, Mother Courage tries to plead her case, but the Captain isn't in yet, so she has to wait for him. She ends up in conversation with a Young Soldier who, she soon learns, was the one to recover Swiss Cheese's cashbox from the river—but never got compensated for it. The Young Soldier furiously demands justice. But Mother Courage knows better: she has spent her whole life waiting for justice, and she knows that it never arrives. In times of war, Brecht warns, appealing to justice is as futile as appealing to God: the people with power have that power because they obey no higher law, so the people without power have no option but to put up or shut up.

Scene 6 Quotes

☞ IN WAR MORE CHRISTIAN SOULS THAN EVER REACH THEIR ETERNAL RESTING PLACE.

[...]

AND WHAT IS WAR? THIS IS MY THESIS:
IT'S WHAT THE WORLD IS FOUNDED ON.
War is like love: it'll always find a way. Why *should* it end?

Related Characters: The Chaplain (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 76

Explanation and Analysis

Mother Courage considers going to stock up on supplies, but she can't decide whether it's really necessary; even though the war has been going for years, she doesn't know how long it will continue. The Chaplain responds with "The Army Chaplain's Song," in which he praises the glory of war. In fact, he describes war as the foundation for everything else in the world ("like love"). Perhaps the most egregious part of his song is his proud declaration that war brings "Christian souls" to "their eternal resting place." He means that they die and go to heaven—and the more, apparently, the merrier.

In his song, the Chaplain is being partly honest, partly facetious. He clearly sees the absurdity and brutality of the war, but he also knows that his job depends on it. So he tells Mother Courage what he always preaches—the war is a holy crusade that must go on—even though he clearly doesn't believe it. Beyond his twisted, cynical valorization of death in war, his portrait of war as "what the world is founded on" is very significant, too. The classic religious notion that the world is founded on God's love implies that human love, too, is the force that holds the species together; in short, giving and receiving love is a central motivation in our lives. (The Chaplain offers a new take on this when he suggests that soldiers should have more children to keep the war going.)

But if the world is founded on *war*, as the Chaplain suggests, then the drive to destroy the other is fundamental—not the desire to unite with them through love. This cynical perspective fits cleanly with the Chaplain, Mother Courage, and all the other characters' fundamentally self-interested motivations and worldview.

☞ She's finished. How would she ever get a husband now? And she's crazy for children. Even her dumbness comes from the war. A soldier stuck something in her mouth when she was little. I'll never see Swiss Cheese again, and where my Eilif is the Good Lord knows. Curse the war!

Related Characters: Mother Courage, The Chaplain (speaker), Eilif, Swiss Cheese, Katrin

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 81**Explanation and Analysis**

Mother Courage sends Katrin out for supplies, but when she returns, she has a huge gash above her eye. In a pattern that recurs throughout the play, as though to highlight that the violence of war and the violence of capitalism are one and the same, violence occurs at the same time as Mother Courage makes her profits. A soldier has attacked Katrin, and while it's not clear exactly what she has suffered, it is clear that she will spend the rest of her life with a massive scar. Mother Courage immediately realizes that no man will marry Katrin with her scar—and Katrin presumably also knows this. It's significant that Katrin's scar will pose a problem for her marriage, whereas her muteness would not—this shows how women were valued for their appearances in the 1600s, not their personalities. (It also suggests that Mother Courage is an exception to the norm, as a strong single mother who makes a living on her own.)

Mother Courage also mentions another crucial detail: Katrin's "dumbness" (muteness) is also the result of trauma she experienced in the war. In fact, she strongly implies that the soldier raped Katrin when she was a child. This brings a whole new meaning to Katrin's role in the play: the violence of war has silenced her, although that does not mean that she does not understand or protest against it. She represents the living legacy of the war's cruelty and trauma in a way that Mother Courage's sons, who die, cannot. And now, she has lost the last thing that mattered to her: the chance of marrying.

Katrin's suffering also represents Mother Courage's guilt and failure as a parent. After all, it is Mother Courage who put her own children in harm's way—even though they are children of the war, she could have raised them safely at home in Sweden instead of on the battlefield. This is one of the few times in the play when Mother Courage turns sour about the war: she seems to recognize her mistake and "curse the war" for bringing her all the tragedy she feared but none of the riches she dreamed about.

Scene 8 Quotes

☞ Don't tell me peace has broken out—I've gone and bought all these supplies!

Related Characters: Mother Courage (speaker)**Related Themes:**  **Page Number:** 84**Explanation and Analysis**

Mother Courage buys more supplies at the Chaplain's encouragement in the sixth scene, only for the war to end shortly after in this scene, leaving her with a vast stock of surplus merchandise. She is furious: this is the worst possible timing for peace; it is undermining her business. So, like the Top Sergeant and Recruiting Officer in the first scene, she curses peace as a waste of time and resources. Her rather unsympathetic position shows the moral compromise involved in profiting from war: since she puts her financial self-interest above everything else, she prefers for death and destruction to continue—even as it swallows up her children. Ironically, she announced, "Curse the war!" just a few moments earlier, at the end of the same scene in which she bought supplies, when Katrin returned from fetching them with a scar. But that fury has clearly passed, and now she cares more about her profit margins than Katrin's scar or marriage prospects.

☞ CHAPLAIN. *Your intentions are only too transparent!* (to MOTHER COURAGE:) But when I see *you* take peace between finger and thumb like a snotty old handkerchief, the humanity in me rebels! You want war, do you? Well, don't you forget the proverb: who sups with the devil must use a long spoon!

MOTHER COURAGE. Remember what one fox said to another that was caught in a trap? "If you stay there, you're just asking for trouble." I'm not in love with war, Mr. Army Chaplain, and when it comes to calling people hyenas, you and I part company!

CHAPLAIN. Then why all this grumbling about the peace? Is it just for the junk in your wagon?

MOTHER COURAGE. My goods are not junk. I live off them.

CHAPLAIN. You live off war. Exactly!

Related Characters: Mother Courage, The Chaplain (speaker)**Related Themes:**   **Related Symbols:** **Page Number:** 87-88**Explanation and Analysis**

When the war (very temporarily) ends, conflict breaks out between Mother Courage and the Chaplain instead. (But it's not just them: the Cook and Yvette Pottier soon show up and get into a similar shouting match.) The Chaplain criticizes Mother Courage's desire for the war to continue. She cares only about her financial prospects, he alleges, and she shows a complete and utter indifference to the value of human life that ending the war will save. Someone has finally confronted her with the truth—which the audience has seen all along.

In response, Mother Courage protests that she doesn't love war itself—rather, the situation has “caught [her] in a trap” by leaving her with goods she cannot sell. She claims to be a pragmatist, not a warmonger, but the Chaplain suggests that there's really no difference. Of course, the deeper irony here is that exactly the same thing is true of the Chaplain, too: he *also* lives off the war, and he will *also* see his prospects dwindle now that it has ended. He is no better than her—in fact, perhaps he is criticizing her just so he can feel better about himself.

●● CHAPLAIN. What has he done?

SOLDIER. He broke in on a peasant. The wife is dead.

CHAPLAIN. Eilif, how could you?

EILIF. It's no different. It's what I did before.

COOK. That was in wartime.

EILIF. Shut your mouth. Can I sit down till she comes?

SOLDIER. No.

CHAPLAIN. It's true. In wartime they honored him for it. He sat at the Commander's right hand. It was bravery.

Related Characters: Eilif, The Chaplain (speaker), The Swedish Commander

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 92

Explanation and Analysis

While Mother Courage is away on business in town, a soldier marches Eilif by the camp, where the Cook and Chaplain are waiting. They are surprised to learn that he has been disciplined for attacking a peasant family. But the part that surprises them is less the attack than the discipline. The war has ended, however briefly, and indiscriminately massacring peasants is no longer tolerated. As the Chaplain points out here, the same traits that made Eilif a hero now make him a criminal; the difference between a hero and

villain, in other words, is not what they do but *when* they do it and whether those around them reward them for it. In times of war, ferocity, sadism, and remorselessness are virtues; but in ordinary life, they are sins. This speaks to the brutality and inhumanity of war, which gives free license to humanity's darkest traits.

Eilif's punishment will be death, and yet Mother Courage will never learn what happens to him because she is away. The Chaplain takes the opportunity to leave, as well—perhaps so he doesn't have to admit to Mother Courage what he saw. In fact, Mother Courage's absence for Eilif's death is also part of a pattern: she also misses Swiss Cheese and Katrin's deaths, all because she is busy trying to make money. This again underlines the sense in which her profit-seeking is responsible for her children's demise.

Scene 9 Quotes

●● MOTHER COURAGE. Katrin! Where do you think you're going? (*She examines the bundle.*) Ah! So you were listening? I told him: nothing doing—he can have his lousy inn. (*Now she sees the skirt and pants.*) Oh, you stupid girl! Now what if I'd seen that, and you'd been gone! (KATRIN *tries to leave. Her mother holds her.*) And don't imagine I sent him packing on your account. It was the wagon. They can't part me from my wagon. Now we'll put the cook's things here where he'll find 'em, that silly man. You and I are leaving. (*She climbs upon the wagon and throws the rest of the COOK's few things down on to the pants.*) There! He's fired! The last man I'll ever take into *this* business! Get into harness, Katrin. This winter will pass like all the others.

Related Characters: Mother Courage (speaker), Katrin, The Cook

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 101

Explanation and Analysis

In the ninth scene, Mother Courage, the Cook, and Katrin are stranded in the mountains during winter, but they persuade the local Parson (minister) to give them soup by singing him a song. The Cook also tries to get Mother Courage to follow him back to Holland, where he has a job waiting for him in Utrecht: his own mother has just died, and he is inheriting her inn. Mother Courage is interested in the

proposition, but there's a catch: Kattrin can't come.

While Mother Courage and the Cook go inside to get their soup, Kattrin furiously packs her things. But Mother Courage comes outside with the soup, finds her, and chastises her for thinking she was really going to leave without her. While Mother Courage cruelly explains that she actually came back for the wagon—not Kattrin—audiences may not agree. After all, Mother Courage depends heavily on Kattrin, not just to pull the wagon and help her with day-to-day tasks, but also for her sense of self, hope, and emotional stability. Indeed, despite her cold attitude toward Kattrin, this is one of the few scenes in which Mother Courage's humanity shines through—even if it's also a prelude to the play's much darker conclusion.

children's lives: Kattrin's martyrdom.

This scene is also the one and only time when the audience encounters Kattrin alone, making decisions for herself without Mother Courage present. (The only possible exception is when she puts on Yvette Pottier's boots in the third scene.) This makes the ensuing violence all the more significant: Kattrin finally gets the opportunity to speak for herself, as it were, and she takes it. Lastly, her actions also give the audience a chance to consider the significance of her *silence* throughout the play. She has had countless encounters with soldiers like this over the course of her life, some harmless, others traumatic. The war is still in full swing, and it's doubtful that it will ever resolve; although her perspective may be difficult to imagine, it's clear that—unlike Mother Courage—she sees the war as an ongoing nightmare and wants it to stop.

Scene 11 Quotes

☛☛ LIEUTENANT (pointing to the wagon on which KATTRIN has appeared). There's another. (A SOLDIER pulls her out.) Is this everybody?

OLD PEASANT. That's our son.

PEASANT WOMAN. And that's a girl that can't talk. Her mother's in town buying up stocks because the shopkeepers are running away and selling cheap.

OLD PEASANT. They're canteen people.

Related Characters: The Lieutenant, Old Peasant, Old Peasant Woman (speaker), Mother Courage, Kattrin

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 103

Explanation and Analysis

The play's climax takes place near the German city of Halle. A group of soldiers confronts the peasant family sheltering Mother Courage and Kattrin (by letting them park their wagon outside). Kattrin is in the wagon, and the soldiers drag her out, but Mother Courage is away in town. As the Old Peasant Woman explains, the townspeople are worried about the coming violence, so Mother Courage is taking advantage of the situation to buy shopkeepers' remaining wares at a discount. As always, her profits are closely tied to the fate of the war—they rise roughly in proportion to the suffering of the people around her. This also means that she will yet again miss the most fateful moment in one of her

☛☛ (KATTRIN, unperceived, has crept off to the wagon, has taken something out of it, put it under her skirt, and has climbed up the ladder to the roof.)

PEASANT WOMAN. Be mindful of the children in danger, especially the little ones, be mindful of the old folk who cannot move, and of all Christian souls, O Lord.

Related Characters: Old Peasant Woman (speaker), Kattrin, Young Peasant

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 106

Explanation and Analysis

After the soldiers force the Young Peasant to guide them into Halle, the Old Peasant Woman prays. She futilely asks God to save the town's people—something he has not done to any of the other millions of peasants who have died horrible, senseless deaths in the Thirty Years' War. And she particularly focuses on the town's children, including her own grandchildren.

At precisely this moment, Kattrin makes her decisive, heroic move, finally taking matters into her own hands. She hides a drum in her skirt and climbs up onto the family's roof; from there, she will beat the drum to warn the people about the coming army. She will give up her life, but in the process, she may save countless others—Brecht does not tell his audiences, and of course, this is part of the point. They must

understand Katrin's sacrifice on its own terms, not as a calculation of lives saved versus lost, but as a protest against the brutality of war and a leap of faith in the power of humanity. By centering the play's climax on this dilemma—prayer versus action, faith in God's will versus faith in humanity's—Brecht also sends his audiences a clear and powerful message about the dangers coming in World War II. Hopes and prayers will do nothing to stop the violence, he warns: only human action, up to and including martyrdom, can make a difference.

hope: Brecht shows that people *can* maintain their sense of humanity, their moral compass, and their sympathy for the weak, even in times of war. Indeed, Katrin was conceived and born during the war, then lived her whole life during it—she knows nothing else. But despite this, unlike her mother, she can see past her own self-interest—she is even willing to die for the sake of solidarity. Above all, Katrin's martyrdom is a metaphor for what Brecht aims to do with this play: offer a dire warning to Europe's people about the calamities to come under the Nazi regime.

☞☞ *(The soldiers arrive with the gun.)*

LIEUTENANT. Set it up! (Calling while the gun is set up on forks:) Once and for all, stop that drumming! (Still crying, KATRIN is drumming as hard as she can.) Fire!

(The soldiers fire. KATRIN is hit. She gives the drum another feeble beat or two, then collapses.)

LIEUTENANT. So that ends the noise.

(But the last beats of the drum are lost in the din of cannon from the town. Mingled with the thunder of cannon, alarm-bells are heard in the distance.)

FIRST SOLDIER. She made it.

Related Characters: The Lieutenant (speaker), Katrin

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 109

Explanation and Analysis

Katrin defiantly keeps beating her drum, even after the soldiers return to the farmhouse, order her to stop, and threaten to kill her. Their threat is completely serious, but so is she—clearly aware that it will cost her life, she continues beating her drum to warn the people of Halle about the coming invasion. The soldiers kill her, completing Mother Courage's fateful prediction in the first scene that she would lose all three of her children.

But unlike Swiss Cheese and Eilif's deaths, Katrin's death really means something. Just when the Lieutenant declares "the noise" over, the city defies him by erupting in resistance, showing that Katrin succeeded in warning the townspeople in time for them to defend themselves. (The other soldier even appears to be impressed: he declares that Katrin "made it," meaning that she achieved what she hoped to.)

Katrin's violent death offers one final, bombastic reminder about the brutalities of war. But it also carries a message of

Scene 12 Quotes

☞☞ LULLAY, LULLAY, WHAT'S THAT IN THE HAY?
THE NEIGHBOR'S KIDS CRY BUT MINE ARE GAY.
THE NEIGHBOR'S KIDS ARE DRESSED IN DIRT:
YOUR SILKS WERE CUT FROM AN ANGEL'S SKIRT.
THEY ARE ALL STARVING. YOU HAVE A CAKE
IF IT'S TOO STALE, YOU NEED BUT SPEAK.
LULLAY, LULLAY, WHAT'S RUSTLING THERE?
ONE LAD FELL IN POLAND. THE OTHER IS—WHERE?

Related Characters: Mother Courage (speaker), Eilif, Swiss Cheese, Katrin

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 110

Explanation and Analysis

In the play's final scene, Mother Courage returns to the peasant family's house and encounters Katrin's body. Like when she sees Swiss Cheese's body, she must confront the dreadful consequences of making a living at war. But she reacts with denial: she asks if Katrin might just be sleeping, and she sings this ambivalent lullaby, imagining the happy family she never had. She displays warmth and tenderness for one of the only times in the play, showing the audience that she actually does feel some kind of maternal instinct and warmth. But she suppressed and sublimated that instinct to her commercial one, which led her to put her children in peril. With this scene, Brecht tries to evoke a delicate balance between emotion and analysis in his audiences—he wants them to sympathize with Mother Courage's loss, to some extent, but also to recognize that she is responsible for it and, thus, condemn her actions.

Mother Courage's lullaby also shows that, even though her relationship with Katrin was full of spite and conflict, in a way it was also the most intimate. Mother Courage and Katrin deeply understood one another, relied on each

other, and stuck together in a way that Mother Courage and her sons simply did not. Katrin was also the last child Mother Courage had left, so her death leaves Mother Courage truly alone for the first time.

☞ OLD PEASANT. Have you no one left?

MOTHER COURAGE. Yes, my son Eilif.

OLD PEASANT. Find him then, leave *her* to us.

PEASANT WOMAN. We'll give her a proper burial, you needn't worry.

MOTHER COURAGE. Here's a little money for the expenses. (*She harnesses herself to the wagon.*) I hope I can pull the wagon by myself. Yes, I'll manage. There's not much in it now. (*The last regiment is heard passing.*) Hey! Take me with you!

Related Characters: Mother Courage, Old Peasant, Old Peasant Woman (speaker), Eilif

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 110-111

Explanation and Analysis

Readers and audiences won't be surprised to learn that *Mother Courage and Her Children* doesn't have a happy ending. In fact, it does end with Mother Courage *feeling* a vague sense of optimism—she muses that at least her son Eilif is alive and starts following a new regiment of soldiers, pursuing the same fantasy of profit that has driven her to follow the war her whole life. But her optimism is actually what makes this scene so dark. As the audience already knows, Eilif is dead, and the soldiers whom Mother Courage wishes to join are the same men who killed Katrin. So Mother Courage ends the play by allying with her daughter's murderers and going on in pursuit of an impossible fantasy (reuniting with Eilif). So she trudges on, alone and desperate, into years more of war; her tireless, delusional optimism about her canteen making her rich is precisely the tragic flaw that has ruined her family, and she can't seem to let go of it. With this conclusion, Brecht reiterates his fateful warning one final time: the danger is not only war itself, but also our capacity to valorize and get used to war. People make war more likely—and more destructive—when they accept it as normal, inevitable, or glorious. And people delude themselves terribly when, like Mother Courage, they see war as an *opportunity*.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PROLOGUE

Mother Courage sits on her **wagon** with her daughter Katrin while her sons Eilif and Swiss Cheese pull it. She sings “The Song Of Mother Courage” while Katrin plays the harmonica, and her sons join the refrains. The song describes how she sells soldiers **beer and wine**, which gives them the courage to face sure death in battle. She sings to the troops that she will sell them food to “fill up the hole in your belly / Before you fill one underground.” Winter is ending, she sings to them in the refrain, “And though you may not long survive, / Get out of bed and look alive!”

Like with all of the play's songs, this opening number's jovial tone sharply contrasts with its serious subject matter. Indeed, the play's protagonists introduce Mother Courage's morally dubious profession, then underline the war's senselessness and brutality by suggesting that her real purpose is to give soldiers the liquor they need to accept a meaningless death. In this way, this scene strongly exemplifies Brecht's famous distancing (or alienation) effect—the characters directly tell the audience the message that is supposed to be the play's subtext. (Presumably, the actual Mother Courage would not have thought the things she sings about here.) This scene also advances the distancing effect through its form: rather than playing out any realistic scenes, the actors make it clear that they are performing a contrived spectacle for the audience. Notably, their haunting song is as much a warning for the audience—Europeans on the eve of World War II—as it is for the soldier characters in the play.



SCENE 1

In rural Sweden in 1624, two military men, the Top Sergeant and the Recruiting Officer, are looking to recruit young men to join the Thirty Years' War. The Recruiting Officer is worried that his recruits will take their own lives, and the Sergeant declares that the Swedes are disorganized and wasteful because they haven't had a war—which would force them to put all their men, food, and equipment to good use.

The soldiers' conversation makes the stakes of war clear: it is a machine for destroying human beings so that a select few people (like the King, the military officers, and, indeed, Mother Courage) can profit. The Recruiting Officer's comment shows that even their recruits quickly realize that fighting is a losing proposition—and commit suicide in despair. Meanwhile, the Sergeant's comment, which echoes the Nazi regime's beliefs about the economic benefits of war, shows how treacherous the profit motive can be when taken to its logical conclusion.



Mother Courage and her children (Katrin, Eilif, and Swiss Cheese) approach on their **wagon**. The soldiers demand to see the family's business license. Eilif and Swiss Cheese explain that everyone knows Mother Courage, who got her name after driving her wagon right through a major battle in Riga. Mother Courage shows the soldiers some papers: a Bible (whose pages she uses to wrap vegetables), a map showing Moravia (where she has never been), and a certificate of health for her horse (which died). She explains that her license is her "honest face." Her real name is Anna Fierling, she continues, but her children all have different names. Eilif's surname is Noyocki because his father's was something similar. Swiss Cheese's father was Swiss, but when he was born, Mother Courage was with a Hungarian man, so he took the name Feyos. Katrin's last name is Haupt because her father is German.

The Recruiting Officer compares Eilif and Swiss Cheese to oxen because they are pulling the **wagon**. Eilif asks Mother Courage for permission to "smack him in the puss [face]." Mother Courage tries to sell the soldiers guns or belts, but they want Eilif instead. They promise him money, fame, and new boots if he joins the army, but he refuses. Mother Courage draws her knife and insists that her family are just merchants, not soldiers. The Top Sergeant mocks Eilif for being afraid of war, then talks about his own successful career in the military. But Mother Courage declares that the Sergeant will die soon. Swiss Cheese explains that she can see the future.

Mother Courage puts two folded pieces of parchment in the Top Sergeant's helmet: one is blank, and the other has a black cross on it (which represents death). She mixes them up, then pulls out the black cross. The Sergeant protests and insists that he's taking Eilif. Surprisingly, Eilif agrees to go—and says that Swiss Cheese wants to fight, too. Mother Courage draws lots for all three of her children, and to her dismay, all three are black crosses. Seeing how seriously Mother Courage's family takes this, the Sergeant grows fearful and complains that his own black cross was a mistake. At the Recruiting Officer's suggestion, the Sergeant buys a belt from Mother Courage for half a guilder, hoping this will save him.

Mother Courage's children introduce her by describing her defining character trait—her unquestioned, often self-defeating perseverance. Notably, the Riga story also explicitly links her to the character of her same name from German folklore. Her use of the Bible to wrap vegetables represents the way that war makes a mockery of religion—the people who join it are forgotten and left to die, as though forsaken by God. What's more, the Thirty Years' War used religion as a thinly-veiled excuse for leading thousands of soldiers to their deaths. Lastly, Mother Courage's comments about her children's fathers reflect how her job has made her transient and prevented her from forming enduring ties. Her story should leave the audience asking questions as the rest of the play unfolds: how did she meet these men? Are they still alive? Did she fall in love with them, was she a sex worker, or did she suffer sexual violence?



The Recruiting Officer's comment suggests that both war and capitalism degrade human beings to the status of animals, beasts of burden who get used for others' benefit. Despite this warning, the Sergeant tries to recruit Eilif into the war by manipulating his ego and his sense of masculine pride. Again, this suggests that men only agree to fight and die in the war when they are manipulated into doing so—they clearly would not do so of their own free will. Lastly, Mother Courage's fortune-telling ability is another example of the estrangement effect: it comes out of nowhere, with no explanation or connection to the preceding plot elements. It is meant to be jarring to the audience, remind them that they are watching an artificial narrative, and force them to ask what Brecht's true intentions are.



Mother Courage's fortune-telling also blatantly foreshadows the play's conclusion: all of her children will die. The Sergeant's concern demonstrates that, despite all his pomp and show, he is actually terrified of the realities of war—which will require him to face his mortality. He tries to avoid this fate through commerce, which reflects back Mother Courage's attitude toward life. It's also a convenient metaphor for both capitalism and war, which Brecht presents as foolish, doomed attempts to cheat fate for personal advantage.



While Mother Courage takes the Top Sergeant behind her wagon to sell him the belt, the Recruiting Officer grabs Eilif and leads him away. Kattrin makes disapproving noises. Mother Courage returns to the front of her wagon, notices that Eilif is gone, and explains that Kattrin can't speak. Kattrin and Swiss Cheese pull the wagon away, and the Sergeant exclaims, "When a war gives you all you earn / One day it may claim something in return!"

Mother Courage loses Eilif in part because her thirst for profit distracts her, and in part because he foolishly believes that war will bring him glory. (Brecht has already clearly shown that it will not.) Kattrin's muteness is another incongruent, unexplained, and alienating plot point. It will take on powerful new meanings later in the play, but for now, suffice it to say that she has been traumatized and silenced by the war but keenly observes everything that goes on around her.



SCENE 2

The stage directions explain that Mother Courage has followed the Swedish army through Poland for nearly two years to Wallhof, where she will unexpectedly meet Eilif in the Swedish Commander's tent. The scene opens with her negotiating a deal with the Dutch Cook: she wants 60 hellers for a capon, but he protests that they're usually "ten hellers a dozen." She points out that they're in a siege; he replies that the Swedes are the attackers, not the victims; but she notes that they don't have any food either and that the local farmers are dying of hunger. The Cook wants 30 hellers, but Mother Courage refuses and leaves him to finish his stew of rancid beef.

Mother Courage's price-gouging again shows that she's involved in the war primarily because she sees it as a great business opportunity. Her willingness to let the soldiers starve if she doesn't get the price she wants exemplifies what Brecht saw as the fundamental brutality of capitalism: by definition, it puts profit above all else, including human life and well-being. Yet the Cook's comments about the siege suggest that optimism about the war is foolish—rather, they demonstrate that war is brutal, miserable, and counterproductive even for its victors.



Eilif enters with the Swedish Commander and the Chaplain. The Commander praises Eilif's heroism but complains about the ungrateful local peasants hiding their oxen (even though the Swedes are there "to save their souls"). Eilif asks the Cook for meat and complains that "skinning peasants" is exhausting. Suddenly, Mother Courage recognizes her son (but he doesn't see her). She remarks that he must be doing well in the army and tells the Cook to buy the capon for 100 hellers. He protests, but reluctantly agrees. She starts plucking off its feathers.

Mother Courage is surprised to meet Eilif, but the audience is not surprised to see it happen: Brecht has already explicitly said this would happen in his stage directions, which are meant to be read aloud. This is another example of how he uses unconventional theatrical techniques to alienate his audience—to draw them out of the story and force them to analyze it, rather than drawing them into it and entertaining them. Brecht sets up a parallel between Eilif "skinning peasants" and Mother Courage plucking the chicken. Again, the comparison between humans and animals underlines how war destroys everything that makes human beings civilized. Lastly, it's telling that Mother Courage's first instinct when she recognizes Eilif is to raise the price on the capon—again, this shows that her single-minded obsession with commerce cuts her off from the emotional connections that give true, deeper meaning to human life.



The Commander invites Eilif to keep drinking and asks him to tell the story of how he got the oxen back. Eilif explains that he followed the peasants into the woods, where they were keeping the oxen, but they quickly cornered him. So he offered them money for the oxen. Confused, they paused, and he killed them. He remarks that “necessity knows no law,” and while the Chaplain notes that this phrase is not actually in the Bible, the Commander praises Eilif for bravely saving their soldiers from hunger. Mother Courage comments that good commanders make plans that ordinary soldiers can fulfill, so only an incompetent commander would need *brave* soldiers to win.

Eilif's story demonstrates that the war has turned him into a monster by rewarding his most sadistic and brutal tendencies. He uses the often-misattributed line “necessity knows no law” to justify his actions, as though he had no option but to murder the peasant family because he was hungry. Clearly, this is an excuse, not the truth. (After all, he never considers the peasants’ necessity, and Mother Courage’s capon sale shows that the army had other way of finding food.) The Chaplain’s response shows how rulers—including the kings involved in the Thirty Years’ War, but also the Nazis in Brecht’s contemporary moment—twist religion to their own political ends, turning it into a justification for conquest and violence. Lastly, Mother Courage’s counterintuitive comment about bravery points to a motif that recurs throughout the play: war turns virtues (like bravery, honesty, and courage) into liabilities.



The Commander guesses that Eilif’s father was a soldier; Eilif says he’s right and sings a song that his mother always sang: “The Fishwife and the Soldier.” In the song, an old fisherman’s wife warns a young soldier boy against going out to sea. But he says that he will live the life of a hero, marching across Europe with his gun and knife. He wades out into the water one night and the tide sweeps him away.

The mention of Eilif’s father again raises subtle but significant questions about the nature of his relationship with Mother Courage. Meanwhile, “The Fishwife and the Soldier” again demonstrates Brecht’s alienation effect: Eilif sings presciently about exactly the kind of folly that will lead him to his death.



Mother Courage sings the song’s last stanza. Eilif recognizes her voice, runs to the kitchen, and embraces her. She tells him that Swiss Cheese is an army paymaster now, and that her feet hurt. The Commander asks if Mother Courage has more sons to send to the army, and Mother Courage lovingly hits Eilif over the ear for stealing the peasants’ oxen instead of surrendering to them.

Mother Courage and Eilif’s reunion is a rare moment of hope and tenderness amidst the play’s endless scenes of suffering and brutality. It’s a reminder of the love and human connection that war destroys—and Mother Courage sacrifices by participating in it (and by choosing commerce over family).



SCENE 3

The stage directions explain that three years have passed; Mother Courage, Swiss Cheese, and Katrin will become prisoners of war and Swiss Cheese will soon die. In this scene, Mother Courage and Katrin fold clothes on a cannon while Swiss Cheese looks on in his paymaster uniform and an attractive young sex worker named Yvette Pottier drinks and sews a hat. An Ordnance Officer begs Mother Courage to buy his bullets so he can afford liquor. But she is reluctant to trade in army property, which could get her in trouble. She talks the officer down to a guilder and a half, then sends Katrin to make the payment.

The stage directions again give away the scene’s punchline, eroding any sense of suspense. Along with Mother Courage and Katrin folding their laundry on the cannon, this is another example of the alienation effect, as it encourages the audience to analyze the play’s meaning rather than simply watch and enjoy it. The Ordnance Officer’s trade underlines the soldiers’ desperation and corruption, and Mother Courage’s deal with him again shows what capitalism is really about, to Brecht: profiting off human suffering.



Mother Courage gives Swiss Cheese his underwear for the cold and warns him that nothing is a *must* in the world, not even the weather—except that “your books *must* balance.” She remarks that he’s the paymaster because he’s honest, and the Ordnance Officer takes him away. Yvette complains that they didn’t say goodbye. Mother Courage tells Yvette that the war is raging on, which is good for business, but warns her against drinking in the morning because of her illness. Yvette says that she’s not sick—it’s just a nasty rumor. She says that everyone is avoiding her because her love, a Dutch army cook the girls nicknamed “Peter Piper,” has cheated on her.

Brecht again suggests that Mother Courage's self-interested warmongering is really the foundational principle of modern capitalist societies. Indeed, her adage that “your books must balance” captures the way capitalist maxims have become common wisdom: it’s simply taken for granted that the economy is the foundation of everything, nothing is for certain except death and taxes, and so on. Meanwhile, like many characters and events in this play, Yvette Pottier seems to come out of nowhere, but she plays an important symbolic role. Above all, she serves as a foil for Mother Courage and Katrin, and her story will underline women’s fraught place in war (and societies that depend on it). Moreover, whether or not audiences realize that “Peter Piper” is the Cook from the last scene, this fact will become significant later on in the play.



Yvette sings “The Camp Follower’s Song.” When the enemy army came to her land, she sings, she was just 17. Each of the soldiers took a girl—a Dutch cook took her, and she fell in love. But one winter, the men all disappeared. She foolishly went looking for the cook. Ten years have passed, and she hasn’t found him. After finishing the song, she hides behind the **wagon**. Next, Mother Courage tells Katrin not to fall for a military man because they charm people and then enslave them forever.

Yvette’s story shows that, just like the military tricks young men into giving away their lives by promising them fame and glory, it manipulates young women into doing the same through the promise of love. (Presumably, once she had been with the Cook and was no longer a virgin, she had no choice but to stay with the military as a sex worker because no other man would marry her.) Audiences will probably figure that Mother Courage’s warning to Katrin is based on her own past—and this again raises questions about the potentially traumatic circumstances that led to her having children.



The Chaplain and Cook enter, looking for **brandy**. The Chaplain explains that Eilif has a message for Swiss Cheese, but Mother Courage says Swiss Cheese has left. She complains that Eilif wants to corrupt Swiss Cheese and gives the men money for Eilif. The Cook says that Swiss Cheese may not come back, but the Chaplain protests that “dying for one’s beliefs” in a religious war is a great honor. (The Cook jokes that God’s approval makes the “cheating, plunder, rape, and so forth” legitimate.)

Yvette is out of sight during this portion of the scene, which is why she and the Cook do not recognize one another. The Chaplain’s interest in brandy and absurd comments about the war again show how people use religion to justify atrocities and control one another—including promising them salvation to get them to give up their lives in futile wars. Where the Chaplain sees the hand of God, it’s clear that Brecht sees only power and manipulation.



The Chaplain suggests that the Cook dreams about Mother Courage, but the Cook denies it—he just dreams about a young woman serving **brandy**. Mother Courage says she’ll give them their drink, lest they start “making improper advances out of sheer boredom.” The Chaplain comments in the third-person that the Chaplain is going to do exactly that, and then he asks Mother Courage about her “captivating” daughter Katrin. Mother Courage calls Katrin “respectable,” not “captivating,” then takes the Cook and Chaplain behind the **wagon** to dispense their brandy.

The Cook’s dream and the Chaplain’s comments mix two vices, sex and alcohol, which seem to be soldiers’ only solace amidst the brutality of war. Meanwhile, the Chaplain’s strange meta-commentary again shows the alienation effect at work. First, he briefly breaks character, as though to remind the audience that he is just a character in a play and force them to question the meaning of his actions. Then, he does the opposite of what a Chaplain is supposed to do by shamelessly sexualizing Katrin. In doing so, he again underlines the way that the war uses religion as an excuse for brutality and control.



Changing the subject, Mother Courage blames the Poles for the Swedish invasion of Poland. The Chaplain and Cook agree that the Swedes have a religious obligation to free the Poles from the German Kaiser, and the Cook sings Luther's Hymn, which describes God as a "mighty fortress" protecting the faithful from sin. The Cook remarks that the Swedish King Gustavus "made quite a profit" by conquering Germany, but the Chaplain is offended: he thinks the King's real motive is religion. Mother Courage agrees with the Cook—she comments that "little fellows like you and me" fight on the King's side because they know he's in it for profit, and they are too. They all toast the Protestant flag.

Suddenly, the Catholic army starts firing on the Swedes. The Cook and Ordnance Officer run off to battle, the Chaplain decides to stay, and a soldier tries and fails to wheel away the cannon. When Katrin arrives wearing Yvette's hat and **boots**, Mother Courage compares her to a sex worker and hides the boots behind her **wagon**. Yvette briefly shows up to powder her face and look for her boots, then runs off. Swiss Cheese comes with his cashbox, which Mother Courage tells him to hide. She also removes the Chaplain's coat, rubs dirt all over Katrin's face so the soldiers don't think to kidnap her, and takes down her Protestant flag.

Mother Courage, Swiss Cheese, Katrin, and the Chaplain spend three days anxiously waiting out the battle. The scene picks up on the third morning, as Swiss Cheese worries that his fellow soldiers are looking for him. The group rations out milk, and the Chaplain prays and warns that there are Catholics everywhere—there was even a one-eyed Catholic spy in the hole he was using as a toilet. Mother Courage admonishes Katrin for "strutting like a peacock" in Yvette's stolen **boots**, then takes the Chaplain away to go buy meat and a Catholic flag.

Mother Courage's explanation of the war is self-serving: she blames the victims for being invaded. Presumably, she does this because it helps her justify her job feeding (and profiting from) the invaders. The Cook and Chaplain's claims about their religious obligations serve exactly the same purpose. They're also Brecht's warning about the Nazis, who used religion to justify their violence and conquest in much the same way. Nevertheless, Mother Courage's final comment about the King's real motives—self-interest and profit—shows that, even if she blames the victims for the invasion, she is still the only character who understands the invasion's real purpose. For all her faults, then, in a way, she's actually the most honest character in the play.



When she puts on Yvette's hat and boots, Katrin appears to be fantasizing about being an unbothered, casual young woman—someone who could worry more about looking good and finding a husband than surviving the war and who could derive status and influence from her beauty. When audiences recall that she has lived her whole life in the war and has lost her speech due to her traumatic experiences, it becomes clear why she would dream of an ordinary life. It's telling that Mother Courage rubs dirt on her to make her unattractive: this shows that, like Eilif's bravery, Swiss Cheese's honesty, and Mother Courage's courage, Katrin's beauty is actually a liability for her in the war, since soldiers may kidnap and rape her.



Brecht intentionally defies the conventions of the theater by announcing to his audience that three days have passed in the middle of this scene (instead of just ending it and starting a new scene three days later). Of course, this only underlines the unusual timeline in the play as a whole: most of the scenes are set years apart, such that the plot is more a series of vignettes than a continuous narrative. The Chaplain's odd, improbable comment about a Catholic spy hiding in a hole of the ground contrasts with the play's otherwise serious tone, so it again enacts the "distancing effect," pulling audience members out of the narrative and forcing them to analyze it.



Swiss Cheese hatches a plan to bury his cashbox near the river so that he can eventually bring it back to his sergeant. Katrin goes behind the **wagon**, where two soldiers (the Sergeant and One Eye) confront her, asking for Swiss Cheese. She runs back in terror and desperately tries to warn her brother with noises and gestures, but he confidently walks off to bury his cashbox. When Mother Courage and the Chaplain return, Katrin tries to explain what happened through howls and gestures. The Chaplain raises the Catholic flag, then figures out that Katrin is talking about the one-eyed spy.

Unlike most of the soldiers in the play—including Eilif—Swiss Cheese is loyal and honest. He wants to save the cashbox so that he can eventually fulfill his duties as paymaster. But this seems to be putting him in peril. In contrast, the Chaplain has no such sense of honesty or morality. Indeed, it's profoundly ironic that the Chaplain raises the Catholic flag, as his entire job was to create a (Protestant) religious justification for the war. When the situation gets serious, even he is willing to abandon his beliefs and put survival first. In turn, this means that he does not truly believe what he preached: that soldiers should care more about saving their souls than saving their lives.



The Sergeant and One Eye roughly escort Swiss Cheese back to the stage. Swiss Cheese claims that Mother Courage is just the woman who sold him lunch, and she offers the soldiers **brandy**, but they refuse. The soldiers insist that Swiss Cheese was hiding something under his shirt. They demand to know where the cashbox is, threaten to kill Swiss Cheese, and lead him off. Mother Courage begs Swiss Cheese to tell the truth and save himself.

In the war, just like Eilif's bravery turns him into a monster, Swiss Cheese's honesty ends up putting him in peril. Again, Brecht's message is clear: war is cruel and inhuman, so it rewards the immoral and punishes the virtuous. In fact, Swiss Cheese's interaction with the Catholic soldiers in this scene rehashes this dynamic on a smaller scale. Namely, staying loyal and honest to his commander requires lying to the soldiers.



That evening, Mother Courage explains that she has a plan to pawn her **wagon** and buy Swiss Cheese's freedom. Yvette enters with an elderly Colonel, tells him that she would love to buy Mother Courage's wagon, and says that a blond Lieutenant promised to lend her money. The Colonel jealously tells her not to trust the Lieutenant and agrees to pay 200 guilders for the wagon. Mother Courage has two weeks to pay the money back if she wants to recover the wagon. Yvette gets on the wagon and promises to follow the Colonel to camp, and the Colonel leaves.

While Mother Courage's plot to rescue Swiss Cheese demonstrates that she cares deeply about her children, it's telling that she tries to save him by means of her overriding obsession in life: commerce. Perhaps she cannot conceive of anything else to do, as she has dedicated her life to trading, or perhaps she thinks that the soldiers are more likely to give Swiss Cheese back if there's profit in it for them. Yvette's chat with the Colonel shows how war turns love into a transaction, too. This is true in both directions: he buys her time and affection, while she uses him to get the loan for Mother Courage.



Mother Courage begs Yvette to follow through with the promise she has already made: to give One Eye the 200 guilders as a bribe to save Swiss Cheese, who is facing a court marshal in an hour. Yvette leaves and Mother Courage explains the rest of her plan: once Swiss Cheese is free, she will buy back the **wagon** with the money from his cashbox. Yvette returns and reports that One Eye agreed to the deal, but Swiss Cheese threw the cashbox in the river when he was captured. Mother Courage desperately asks Yvette to bargain One Eye down to 120 guilders, so she will have something left over to live on.

Mother Courage's knack for negotiation initially appears to be an asset, but all does not go according to plan. Swiss Cheese's last-ditch act of loyalty to the Swedish army—throwing the cashbox into the river so that it won't fall into enemy hands—ironically undermines his mother's plan and may even prevent him from regaining his freedom. Forced to choose between her beloved son and the wagon that is her livelihood, Mother Courage decides to try to save both.



Yvette leaves again, and Mother Courage and Katrin clean knives for a few minutes. Then, Yvette returns to explain that One Eye will only take 200 guilders, and Mother Courage agrees. Yvette runs off, and Mother Courage wonders if she “haggled too long.” The stage goes dark, then lights up, and Yvette returns to tell Mother Courage that it’s too late: they already executed Swiss Cheese. Worse still, the soldiers think Mother Courage is hiding the cashbox, and they’re bringing her Swiss Cheese’s body to see if she admits to knowing him.

Swiss Cheese’s death is tragic because it was so avoidable. But this is precisely Brecht’s point—the most devastating part of war is that the death and destruction it causes is utterly arbitrary and meaningless. Needless to say, Mother Courage’s attempt to bargain down the price of Swiss Cheese’s freedom is in part responsible for his death. Again, Brecht’s message is clear and blunt: when we put profit before human beings, we end up destroying them. The soldiers’ quest for the cashbox only underlines how the toxic combination of war and money turns ordinary people into heartless, self-interested brutes.



Mother Courage holds Katrin’s hand, and surely enough, the soldiers show up with Swiss Cheese’s body on a stretcher. They pull back the sheet to show Mother Courage his face and demand to know if she knew him before the time when she served him lunch. Mother Courage shakes her head no. The soldiers decide that Swiss Cheese’s body will go in the dump because “he has no one that knows him.”

By making audiences watch Mother Courage come face-to-face with her son’s body, Brecht forces them to confront the profound tragedy of war and the depth of human corruption. Worse still, Mother Courage must pretend not to know Swiss Cheese, hiding her sorrow and going on in her life with the knowledge that he never got the burial he deserved. Once again, audiences must strike a balance between profound sympathy for Mother Courage and outrage at how she ends up destroying her own family through her warmongering and obsession with profit.



SCENE 4

Mother Courage waits by an army tent, singing “The Song of the Great Capitulation.” A Regimental Clerk recognizes her as the woman who harbored the paymaster (Swiss Cheese). She claims to be innocent and protests that the army destroyed her **wagon** and fined her five thalers. The Clerk tells her to keep quiet, but she insists on complaining to the Captain.

As though confronting Swiss Cheese’s body at the end of the last scene wasn’t humiliating enough, Mother Courage must now beg his murderers for mercy so that she and Katrin do not end up penniless and stranded. It remains to be seen whether she will learn her lesson and change her ways.



A furious Young Soldier arrives and starts cursing the Captain, who stole his reward money and spent it on **brandy** and sex workers. An Older Soldier tells the Young Soldier to stay in line, as the Young Soldier complains that he was the only one willing to swim in the river. Mother Courage promises that she understands the Young Soldier’s frustration, but when he insists that he “won’t stand for injustice,” she points out that he has no other option. She predicts that his rage will die down, but he promises to kill the Captain. At the Clerk’s orders, they both sit.

The Captain’s corruption underlines the way that war is really about power and self-interest—no matter what the war’s organizers say, there is no real principle behind it, least of all justice. Notably, the Young Soldier’s story suggests that he swam in the river and retrieved Swiss Cheese’s cashbox on behalf of his Captain. In this way, he becomes a foil for Swiss Cheese, who also thought that his loyalty would save him (but ended up facing punishment for it).



Mother Courage performs “The Song of the Great Capitulation” in full. She sings that she used to think of herself as special, the creator of her own destiny, until “a little bird” told her that she would have to temper her expectations and learn to compromise once she experienced war. She tells the Young Soldier to think seriously about whether it’s worth it to cross the Captain. He decides to leave. The Clerk tells Mother Courage that the Captain is free, but she decides not to complain either, so she leaves too.

“The Song of the Great Capitulation” describes humans’ powerlessness in the face of fate and reminds the audience that war inflicts profound injustice on innocent people. Little does the Young Soldier know that Mother Courage has experienced a far greater injustice than him, losing not just her money but also her son. They both realize that, with no incentive to give them justice, the Captain will probably just ignore them. So they learn to do what Mother Courage is famous for: accept injustice and move on with life.



SCENE 5

After following the war across Europe for two more years, Mother Courage and Katrin end up in a ruined Bavarian town. Catholic soldiers are doing a victory march in the background. Two soldiers ask Mother Courage for **liquor**, even though they don’t have any money, and complain that their commander only let them plunder the village for an hour. The Chaplain hurries over and explains that a desperate peasant family needs bandages for their wounds. But Mother Courage is out of bandages, and she refuses to gift cloth to customers who can’t pay and will just tear it up. Katrin tries to get some shirts out of the **wagon**, but Mother Courage stops her.

Like Eilif’s comment about “skinning peasants” two scenes prior, the soldiers’ petty complaints here show how war turns ordinary people into monsters who can commit acts of unspeakable cruelty with little second thought. But Mother Courage’s attitude to the Chaplain’s request shows that she is no better. She only thinks about money, not life, and so even after all the loss and trauma that she has experienced, she cannot find any sympathy for the helpless, dying peasants.



The Chaplain brings in a dying peasant woman, who explains that she stayed in town instead of fleeing because she wanted to save her farm—and that she needs bandages. But Mother Courage says she can’t afford to foot the bill for the woman’s foolishness. The Chaplain brings over a peasant man from the same house. He has been shot, but Mother Courage’s response is the same. Katrin threatens to hit Mother Courage with a board, and then the Chaplain finds the shirts and starts tearing them up into bandages. Katrin runs over to the peasant family’s house and returns holding a baby and singing it lullabies. Mother Courage furiously tells her to stop. One of the soldiers tries to steal a **liquor** bottle, and Mother Courage snatches his fur coat but lets him go.

Whereas Katrin and the Chaplain’s sense of conscience leads them to do what they can to save the peasant family, Mother Courage again blames the victims. Worse still, she views even this tragic situation as primarily a business opportunity. This suggests that she has learned nothing from losing her son—on the contrary, it seems more and more likely that she will never change, no matter how badly her actions hurt herself and her family. To add insult to injury, she lets the soldier get away with stealing the bottle only because he has something of value. In this way, she is no better than the soldiers—who no doubt got the fur from the village they raided. Brecht’s message is clear: there is little moral difference between committing atrocities and profiting from them.



SCENE 6

The stage directions explain that, at the Catholic General Tilly's funeral in 1632, Mother Courage will speak about heroism, the Chaplain will sing about the war, and Katrin will get her **red boots**. This scene takes place in the canteen tent, with the funeral march audible in the background. Mother Courage explains that the General died that foggy morning after accidentally riding his horse the wrong way, straight into the crossfire. She criticizes the soldiers for **drinking** instead of attending the funeral; the Regimental Clerk agrees, even though he didn't go either. (He blames the rain.)

A soldier sings a "Battle Hymn" demanding a **drink** and a woman because soldiers have "no time to waste." But Mother Courage says he has to pay first. She laments that the "common riffraff" don't even care about their commander's death, and she asks if the war is going to end. (She's low on supplies and wants to know how much more to buy.) The Chaplain promises that the war has a "prosperous future," but the Regimental Clerk says he hopes it ends so he can go home to Bohemia.

The Chaplain remarks that "war satisfies all needs" and sings "The Army Chaplain's Song" about how war gives men food, drink, women, and the eternal salvation of death. He sings that soldiers can keep the war going by having children, and that war is really the foundation of the world. "Like love," he concludes, war will "always find a way." Mother Courage announces that she *will* buy more supplies. When Katrin drops a basket full of glasses and runs away, Mother Courage explains that she promised Katrin could get married once the war is over. Mother Courage gets Katrin, reminds her that the war will ensure that they're wealthy once peace comes, and then sends her to fetch supplies with the Clerk.

The General's futile, pathetic death—a real historical event—becomes a convenient symbol for the absurdity and self-destructiveness of war. Namely, the General failed to distinguish between his friends and his enemies. In a way, this represents the sense in which everyone is out for themselves in the war and all alliances are temporary and futile. And in another, it captures the sense that even the people behind the war are incompetent and unaware of what they are getting into. Rather, Brecht suggests, they participate in war for the same reason as everyone below them in the chain of command: they believe they can fulfill unrealistic fantasies of power, wealth, and glory.



Mother Courage's complaints about the soldiers' disrespect for their commander are ironic. She views herself as superior to them—just as they view themselves as superior to her—but in reality, they are all exactly alike. They all joined the war for the same self-interested reasons. Worse still, all of them think they are outsmarting everyone else, but actually, none of them will get out ahead. The soldiers will spend all their money on liquor and go home with nothing, if they even survive; Mother Courage will never make the fortune she dreams about.



Like the Top Sergeant's comments about "organization" and "The Song of Mother Courage," the Chaplain's song highlights the absurdity of war propaganda by exaggerating it and making its dishonesty clear. The audience knows that the war is really making Europe miserable through endless scarcity, death, and sexual violence. But the Chaplain knows that his job is to sanitize this reality—by painting death as salvation, for instance. In this way, his profession is exactly like Mother Courage's: he depends on the war and will do better the longer it goes on.



Meanwhile, Mother Courage asks the Chaplain to help her cut wood. He reluctantly agrees and asks about her pipe—which he knows she stole from the Swedish Commander’s Dutch Cook. Mother Courage refuses to admit it. The Chaplain says it doesn’t matter, since the Cook was an evil, manipulative man. He chops the wood aggressively as he reminds her that his true talent is preaching, not labor. He says that he knows Mother Courage has a heart under her rough exterior and proposes that they form a “closer relationship.” Mother Courage says no and tells him to keep chopping the wood.

Mother Courage’s penchant for stealing things (like the Cook’s pipe, Yvette’s boots, and the liquor-snatching soldier’s furs) shows that, at base, she’s not really the honest businesswoman she pretends to be. Yet nobody is honest in the army—in fact, the soldiers frequently make it clear that their primary motive for joining the army is to rob and pillage peasants. In other words, the whole enterprise of the war depends on theft and conquest, and Mother Courage’s business is no exception. The Chaplain’s willingness to forgive Mother Courage, like his sexual advances toward her, show that he is also in no way an honest man.



Kattrin returns, but she has a wound near her eye and is dropping all the merchandise she brought. Mother Courage bandages up her wound, promises that it isn’t serious, and gives her Yvette’s **red boots** as a gift. But Kattrin refuses to wear the boots and hides in the **wagon**. Mother Courage tells the Chaplain that Kattrin’s wound will scar and complains that she never knows what Kattrin is thinking. (She even disappeared for a whole night once.) Mother Courage picks up the scattered merchandise and comments that war is “a nice source of income.”

Kattrin has clearly been attacked, but Mother Courage doesn’t take her condition seriously and goes on thinking about her profits instead. When she gives Kattrin Yvette’s boots—which she had stolen years ago in the hopes of selling them for a profit—this represents her trying to repair the damage she has done to Kattrin’s sense of identity and femininity. But clearly, it’s too little, too late: Kattrin wants the boots (her femininity) on her own terms, not on her mother’s.



A cannon blast marks the General’s burial. Mother Courage remarks that nobody will marry Kattrin now, with her scar. She reveals that Kattrin hasn’t spoken since a soldier traumatized her as a child. And she laments that the war has taken all of her children away: “Curse the war!”

Kattrin’s actions, like trying on Yvette’s boots and rescuing the peasant family’s baby, have demonstrated both her desire for love and her maternal instincts. Notably, marriage would also free her from Mother Courage—and the life of war profiteering that, despite her muteness, she clearly disagrees with. In fact, Mother Courage makes an important revelation about the origins of Kattrin’s muteness, too. Her comment raises more questions than it answers, but she seems to be suggesting that a soldier sexually assaulted Kattrin when she was a child. In this way, Kattrin’s muteness represents the trauma that war inflicts on the innocent—particularly women and children.



SCENE 7

Kattrin and the Chaplain pull the **wagon**, which is filthy and falling apart but full of new wares. Mother Courage walks alongside them and announces that nobody can spoil “her” war. War might eliminate “the weak,” she remarks, but “what does peace do for ‘em?” She again sings “The Song of Mother Courage” from the Prologue.

Mother Courage trudges on, steadfast in her pursuit of wealth. But her namesake virtue—courage—is starting to look more and more like folly: it is leading her family to ruin and even degrading the wagon she lives in. Brecht forces the audience to ask if perseverance is truly valuable when directed toward a destructive, futile pursuit like war.



SCENE 8

The stage directions explain that, in this scene, King Gustavus will die, Mother Courage will worry about her business collapsing, and Eilif will “perform one heroic deed too many” and perish. One summer day, an elderly woman and her son approach Mother Courage’s **wagon** at the camp. They have a huge sack of bedding to sell, but Mother Courage doesn’t want to buy it. In the distance, church bells ring and a voice yells that the King of Sweden is dead. Mother Courage is furious—the war can’t end; she just stocked up on supplies. But the distant voice says the war ended three weeks ago. The old woman is stunned; her son rejoices and leads her away.

The Dutch Cook comes to see Mother Courage, who is glad to see him after so many years. He reports that Eilif is on his way. The Chaplain leaves to go put on his pastor’s robes, and Mother Courage tells Kattrin to give the Cook some **brandy**, but she does nothing and refuses to leave the **wagon**. Mother Courage brings the Cook’s drink herself, then starts complaining that the peace is going to bankrupt her. The Cook says she was wrong to listen to the Chaplain, who is misogynistic and unreliable. Mother Courage jokes that the Cook is no better and asks if the soldiers have gotten their back pay. The Cook says no—in fact, the army disbanded after it stopped paying the soldiers.

The Chaplain returns in his robes, and the Cook confronts him, accusing him of interfering with Mother Courage’s business. The Chaplain says he sees the Cook’s intentions and compares Mother Courage to a hyena, as she prefers war over peace. The Cook encourages Mother Courage to start selling her goods at a discount, before they become totally worthless. Mother Courage gets in her **wagon**, and the Cook and Chaplain start trading threats.

Suddenly, Yvette Pottier arrives. She is now older, heavysset, and dressed in a widow’s black. She introduces herself as the Colonel’s wife and asks to see Mother Courage, then calls out her first name. At this point, the Cook realizes who she is. Yvette and the Cook stare at each other in shock, then insult each other’s weight. Yvette remarks that she will finally have the chance to tell the Cook what she really thinks of him, and the Chaplain begs her to do it once Mother Courage arrives.

Mother Courage’s war profiteering leads her to a profoundly cruel, deeply ironic conclusion: she desperately wants the war that has destroyed her family to continue. She doesn’t care whether her king, Gustavus, is dead or alive, or whether Kattrin will finally get to live the quaint married life she dreams about. Rather, she cares only about pursuing her fantasy of getting rich off the war—even though she has spent nearly all her life trying and failing. In contrast, the peasants’ attitude is far more understandable: as the war’s innocent victims, they keep their moral priorities in order.



The Cook and Chaplain aren’t happy about the war ending, either, because their jobs also depend on it. But the Cook’s comments about the Chaplain are ironic, given what the audience has already learned about the Cook from Yvette Pottier: he’s at least as much of a womanizing rake as the Chaplain. Moreover, the army’s haphazard decision to disband itself when it runs out of money again shows that the powerful people running the war are no more organized, dedicated, or realistic than the ordinary people fighting it. They seem to have no greater moral purpose, either: they discard the soldiers as soon as they prove no longer useful.



The Cook, the Chaplain, and Mother Courage start taking out their frustration at losing their jobs on one another. In other words, as soon as the war ends, they ironically break out into conflict. After all, they are the falsest of friends: they may have stuck together during the war, but it was only out of self-interest. None of them truly care about the others, and they would all be willing to undermine the others to get ahead. In fact, the Cook’s comments about Mother Courage’s prices suggest that he is trying to get a discount for himself.



The war is over, but the conflicts continue. Yvette Pottier’s transformation underlines how much time has passed since the beginning of the play. In theory, this should remind audiences of the work’s epic scale and ambitions: Brecht is capturing Mother Courage’s entire life, not just one unfortunate period in it. Yvette’s newfound wealth and status show that she actually managed to achieve her dream—unlike Mother Courage, the Cook, and the Chaplain.



Mother Courage exits her **wagon** and asks why Yvette is in mourning. Yvette replies that her husband—the brother of the Colonel from Scene Three—died some years back. The Chaplain reminds Yvette to tell Mother Courage about the Cook. Yvette identifies him as the seducer Peter Piper, who cheated on her. Mother Courage instantly understands (and mentions that she has his pipe). The Cook claims that he's not like that anymore, but Yvette keeps hurling insults at him. Mother Courage and Yvette leave to try and sell some of Mother Courage's extra goods.

The Chaplain tells the Cook that “the mills of God grind slowly.” The Cook admits that he was just hoping that Mother Courage would feed him, but that probably won't happen now. He complains that he has no job without the war, either. He and the Chaplain reminisce about working for the King.

Eilif arrives, pale, handcuffed, and escorted by two soldiers. He explains that it's his last visit; one soldier makes a throat-cutting gesture while the other explains that Eilif raided a peasant's house, murdered his wife, and stole his cattle. The Chaplain points out that this behavior might be a crime now, but it was considered heroic during wartime. Eilif asks for **brandy**, but the soldiers won't let him have any. He tells the Chaplain not to tell Kattrin, and to tell Mother Courage that he's just the same as before. The Chaplain follows Eilif to perform his last rites (even though Eilif asks him not to), and the Cook tries to coax Kattrin out of the **wagon**.

Mother Courage returns with her goods and triumphantly announces that the war has started up again. The Cook admits that Eilif just passed through, and Mother Courage optimistically replies that they'll meet him soon and he'll definitely survive the war. She asks how Eilif looked, and the Cook says he looked the same. She asks whether Eilif is still doing heroic deeds, and the Cook explains that he actually just performed one. She asks where the Chaplain is, and the Cook says he's with Eilif.

By marrying the Colonel's brother for money, Yvette has done exactly what she accuses the Cook of doing to her: turning love and sex into commodities, which deprives them of their true power and significance. Of course, the key difference is that the Cook fooled her into following him to the war, which ruined her marriage prospects forever, while the Colonel's brother clearly knew what he was getting into. Still, their conflict brims with hypocrisy on all sides, much like when the Cook and Chaplain angrily call each other womanizers.



Even after giving up on the army, raising the Catholic flag, and making sexual advances at Mother Courage and Kattrin in scenes past, the Chaplain somehow returns to his empty religious platitudes. His point is that change and justice often play out slowly, over the course of years or decades, but his statement could also easily be interpreted as saying that God forgets about human beings altogether. Here, unlike the Chaplain, at least the Cook is honest about his motives.



The circumstances surrounding Swiss Cheese's death repeat themselves: Mother Courage ends up missing Eilif's execution, too, because she is away on business. Again, this clearly represents the way that her selfish profit-seeking blinds her to the human stakes of the war and leads to her family's undoing. But so do Eilif's actions: they provide the ultimate proof that war turns ordinary people into monsters. The actions that he earned praise for during the war are horrific crimes in ordinary times—again, wartime morality proves to be the opposite of true morality.



Just like her pessimism when the war ends, Mother Courage's optimism in this section is ironically out of step with reality. She has no idea that Eilif is dead, and tragically, she will never learn, as the Cook can't work up the courage to tell her. Worse still, the war's return means that Eilif might not have been breaking the law, after all—and yet, this doesn't make his actions any less cruel, and nobody, neither he nor his captors, could know the truth.



Mother Courage assures the Cook that his history with Yvette won't affect her view of him. She asks whether the Cook will take over for the Chaplain and accompany her and Katrin, and he agrees and gets in the harness to pull the **wagon**. They take off, singing "The Song of Mother Courage," including a new verse about how people support the war and the war supports the people.

Audiences should immediately recognize the dramatic irony in this scene: the Cook already admitted to the Chaplain that he was only approaching Mother Courage in search of food and drink, and it's clear that the Chaplain has abandoned her for good. She clearly just wants the Cook to go with her so that he can help her run the canteen—and so that she doesn't have to pull the wagon herself. But she still pretends to respect him, and they both still pretend to make an honest agreement in good faith.



SCENE 9

The stage directions explain that, in these 16 years of war, half of Germany's people have died, whether of violence, plague, or hunger. It's 1634 in Bavaria's Fichtel Mountains. Winter has hit hard and early, and Mother Courage's business is struggling. The Cook will soon return home. One gray morning, Mother Courage and the Cook wonder if the local Parson (minister) might share food with them. The Cook shows Mother Courage a letter from home, which states that his mother has died and that he has inherited her inn. Mother Courage admits that she's tired of traveling—she sometimes dreams that she's wandering through heaven or hell.

Brecht yet again uses stage directions unconventionally to get the audience to respond to his work in a rational way (as opposed to an emotional one). By presenting these historical facts, he reminds the audience that Mother Courage and her children's suffering were not the exception but the norm during the Thirty Years' War. His point is clear: by launching World War II, the Nazis are repeating the mistakes of the darkest times in Germany's past. The Cook's excitement about his mother's death is another reminder of how, thanks to the war, broken parent-child relationships pervade this play.



The Cook invites Mother Courage to go run the inn with him, and she proposes the idea to Katrin. But the Cook quietly tells Mother Courage that Katrin can't come—there's no space for her at the inn. (Katrin is secretly listening in and hears everything.) Mother Courage suggests that Katrin could look for a husband, but the Cook says that no man will marry her because of her age and her scar.

The Cook is cruel and dismissive to Katrin in part because he thinks Mother Courage views her as a liability. Unfortunately, Mother Courage's halfhearted response seems to prove him right. Even now, Katrin says nothing but understands everything—and nobody else realizes it. Soon, audiences will learn that, despite her muteness, she is actually the most sane and compassionate character in the whole play.



The Parson's light turns on, and the Cook and Mother Courage sing "The Song of the Wise and Good" to him. The first verse describes how King Solomon's wisdom ruined him by showing him that "all is vanity." The second verse is about Saint Martin killing himself through "unselfishness"—he shared his coat with a beggar in the winter, and both froze to death. Following God and the Ten Commandments has "not done us any good," the Cook sings in the final verse, as he begs the Parson for alms.

"The Song of the Wise and Good" turns traditional moral parables on their head to show how war rewards evil and transforms virtues into liabilities. The first anecdote refers to a verse from Ecclesiastes in which Solomon claims that life without God is vain, or pointless, and the second is a famous story about Saint Martin of Tours. In short, the Cook and Mother Courage are singing to the Parson about how religion has failed them and how God has forsaken them. This adds two more layers of irony: first, the Parson, who is supposed to dedicate his life to God, is actually the wealthiest and most comfortable man in the village; second, the Cook and Mother Courage try to win the Parson's favor precisely by insulting the religion he represents.



In fact, the Parson calls down to them, offering them soup. But the Cook again tells Mother Courage to leave Katrin behind, and she agrees. She goes inside, but quickly returns with soup for Katrin—only to find Katrin outside the **wagon** with a bundle of her possessions, trying to run away. Realizing that Katrin heard her conversation with the Cook, Mother Courage calls her a “stupid girl!” and promises that she wasn’t going to leave her behind—never mind the wagon. Mother Courage tosses the Cook’s things on the ground and promises never to work with a man again. She and Katrin start pulling the wagon away, and once they are gone, the Cook comes outside.

Mother Courage’s willingness to leave Katrin behind again calls into question whether she is really willing to put her family before herself—or if she just views her children as potential sources of labor. But her quick return shows that she actually is loyal to her daughter—even if she isn’t particularly nice to her. Aware that the Cook was using her all along, Mother Courage mercilessly leaves him behind and gets in the harness to pull the wagon herself for the first time.



SCENE 10

Mother Courage and Katrin pull their **wagon** up to a well-to-do farmhouse. A voice sings inside, and they stop to listen. The anonymous singer performs “The Song of Shelter,” which is about planting a tree in spring and watching it bloom during the summer, then spending the winter sheltering inside the farmhouse. Mother Courage and Katrin move on.

This brief scene depends on the juxtaposition between Mother Courage and Katrin’s transient life, on the one hand, and the farmhouse residents’ comfortable, settled one, on the other. Whereas Mother Courage once looked down on peasants as poor and stupid, now she envies them. The message is clear: Mother Courage’s lifelong pursuit of wealth has been a grave error; instead of joining the war effort, she should have stayed home in Sweden and built an ordinary life for herself.



SCENE 11

When Catholics attack the Protestant city of Halle in 1636, the stage directions explain, Katrin will die, Mother Courage will go on alone, and the war still will not end. It is nighttime, and the tattered **wagon** is parked next to a farmhouse. Three soldiers and a Lieutenant knock on the farmhouse door, then bring out the family who live there (Old Peasant, Old Peasant Woman, and Young Peasant). They see Katrin in the wagon and force her to get out of it, too. The Old Peasant Woman explains that Katrin is mute, and her mother is off doing business in town.

This is the play’s pivotal scene and, curiously, is also the only one in which Mother Courage does not appear. (Yet again, she will miss one of her children’s deaths because she is too busy trading.) Instead, Katrin steals the show—and while the stage directions give away their fate, what they do not reveal is that she is about to become the play’s only hero. But first, the scene opens with a pattern of events that is now familiar to the audience: passing soldiers abuse innocent peasants simply for being in the wrong place at the wrong time.



The Lieutenant demands that the son (Young Peasant) show the soldiers the way to town, but he refuses, saying he doesn't know the way and would rather die than help a Catholic. But he finally agrees when the soldiers threaten to kill the family's cattle, and they leave. The farming couple wonders what the soldiers are doing, and the Old Peasant climbs up on his roof to get a better view. He sees a massive regiment of soldiers moving toward the town and realizes that they are going to attack while everyone is asleep. And the watchman hasn't blown his horn, which means the soldiers probably killed him.

The soldiers conscript the peasants into their own community's destruction. The Young Peasant quickly realizes that he will suffer if he doesn't guide them to town (and that they will probably find their way there regardless). This reflects how, in war, victims can easily become perpetrators, and vice versa. The mention of cattle clearly links this situation to Eilif's actions in the third scene, when he bragged about murdering a group of peasants to steal their cattle. Put differently, Kattrin is now experiencing the same terror that her brother was inflicting—and she and her mother have been profiting from.



Terrified, the peasants realize they can't do anything except pray. They beg Kattrin to join them. They all kneel, and the Old Peasant Woman asks God to wake up the townspeople and to save their son-in-law, grandchildren, and farm. While the woman prays, Kattrin quietly pulls a drum out of the **wagon**, hides it in her skirt, and then climbs up to the roof. When the farmers finish their prayer, Kattrin starts beating the drum. The farmers panic, try to get Kattrin down, and even threaten to stone her, but she is unfazed—she keeps playing the drum.

By showing how the peasants take recourse to prayer, Brecht suggests that religion is deeply ingrained in rural Germany—and completely useless. Where the peasants' prayers do nothing, Kattrin takes matters into her own hands: she beats the drum to try and wake up the townspeople before the soldiers arrive and massacre them all. She specifically acts when the peasants mention their grandchildren, which again shows that her concern is specifically about saving children from the horrors of war. Understandably, the peasants fear that the soldiers will turn on them because of Kattrin's actions. This highlights the extent to which Kattrin's self-sacrifice is an exception: she's the only person in the whole play who doesn't prioritize herself above everyone else.



The Lieutenant runs back, threatens to kill the farmers, and demands that Kattrin throw him the drum. But she keeps drumming. A soldier offers to spare Mother Courage, and the Lieutenant offers his sincerest promise as an army officer, but Kattrin ignores them. The Lieutenant proposes making a louder noise to drown out the drum, and the Old Peasant starts chopping wood, but it's not enough. The Lieutenant considers burning down the farm, but the Old Peasant points out that the townspeople would definitely notice that.

With her drum, Kattrin says everything that she has been unable to say throughout the play: she gives voice to her own pain, stands up against soldiers (who have long coerced and abused her), and lodges a protest against the war's senseless, inhuman brutality. Against all the odds, she seems to have cultivated a sense of morality and selfless, nurturing certain caregiving instincts that Mother Courage herself lost long ago (if, indeed, she ever had them). And she makes it clear that her purpose is not to save her mother but rather the children of Halle.



Kattrin starts to laugh as she drums louder and louder. The Lieutenant demands a musket, and his soldiers go to get one. The Old Peasant Woman suggests threatening to break the **wagon**—the Lieutenant tries this, and the Young Peasant even hits the wagon with a board. But Kattrin just pauses, makes a pained sound, and keeps drumming. The Lieutenant tells Kattrin he will shoot her and lies that the townspeople can't hear her drum.

Kattrin continues drumming, desperately and relentlessly, showing that she is willing to die if necessary. Needless to say, her warning to the people of Halle is also Brecht's warning to the people of Europe in the first days of World War II. This is what makes this scene so haunting: modern audiences can imagine the carnage that is beginning in Halle, as they know all too well about the carnage that followed this play in Europe.



The Young Peasant finally switches sides and tells Katrin to keep drumming. In response, the Lieutenant stabs and kills him. Katrin starts to cry, but continues drumming, even as the soldiers bring the gun, set it up, and fire. She falls over dead. As the Lieutenant says, “So that ends the noise,” cannons and alarm bells sound in the distance. One of the soldiers remarks, “She made it.”

The Young Peasant and Katrin's deaths are Brecht's final and most poignant reminder of the senseless violence of war. Yet again, Mother Courage misses one of her children's deaths because she is too busy trying to make a profit. But there is one major difference here: unlike her brothers, Katrin dies a purposeful death. She sacrifices her life in the name of a greater cause—saving others from the war—and in this way she becomes the play's only hero. This helps explain why the soldier comments that “she made it.” Namely, even if Katrin doesn't survive, she made a meaningful impact with her life and took a stand against the war that everyone else just blindly accepted, whether out of fear or weakness.



SCENE 12

Later that night, with the army in the distance, Mother Courage sits with Katrin's body near their **wagon**. The Old Peasant and Old Peasant Woman advise Mother Courage to leave before the soldiers find them. But Mother Courage remarks that maybe Katrin is just sleeping, and she sings a short lullaby about her kids being happy and well-fed—but also dead and missing.

Mother Courage appears to be in denial about Katrin's death, which signals the complete destruction of her family and leaves her utterly alone. Needless to say, this is an understandable reaction to all the trauma that she has experienced—and the guilt that she may feel (but never shows) for leading her children to their deaths.



Mother Courage blames the peasants for what happened to Katrin, because they mentioned their grandchildren. But the peasants blame Mother Courage for going to town in search of profit. Mother Courage again says that Katrin is sleeping, but the peasants repeat the truth and tell Mother Courage to get going, for her own safety.

Mother Courage's comment about the grandchildren again supports the interpretation that Katrin sacrificed her life to save the children from the troops—likely because of the profound trauma that she experienced as a child in the war. But Brecht assumed that his audiences would no doubt see that the peasants' theory is the right one: Mother Courage's thirst for profit and short-sighted faith in the war are the real reasons for Katrin's death. Worse still, as the soldiers approach, Mother Courage's denial now poses a threat to her own life, too.



The Old Peasant asks if Mother Courage has anyone left, and she says that at least her son Eilif is alive. The Old Peasant Woman promises to bury Katrin, and Mother Courage gives them some money to do it. She gets in the harness and starts pulling her **wagon**. The soldiers pass in the distance, and Mother Courage yells out that she wants to go with them.

The play closes with a haunting scene of Mother Courage running eagerly toward the men who slaughtered her daughter in cold blood. But she is not delusional: she is not going because she thinks that these men are sympathetic or will save her, but rather because she knows that selling to them is her best chance at making a profit. Even if Mother Courage has learned her lesson about the perils of war, it seems, it is far too late for her to make a change—and it is not clear what alternative might be lying in store for her. So she continues on, cold and courageous as always, having both suffered and perpetuated the worst evils of humankind. Brecht's message is clear: nobody wins in war—at least, none of the people on the ground do.



In fact, the soldiers are singing “The Song of Mother Courage.” They sing a new verse about how the war devastated three generations, and then the same refrain: “Christians, awake! The winter’s gone! / The snows depart, the dead sleep on. / And though you may not long survive / Get out of bed and look alive!”

The play ends as it began, with “The Song of Mother Courage.” It may have seemed quaint and optimistic at the beginning, particularly to audiences who didn’t know what to expect of the play or didn’t listen particularly closely to its lyrics. But now, it’s all but impossible to misinterpret it in the same way. It’s a cross between a battle hymn and a funeral march, and it makes it clear that Mother Courage has also suffered greatly from her involvement in the war. Like Katrin’s drum, the beat of this song is a dire warning to the people of Europe about precisely what lies in store for them over the next few years.





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